Open-ended research with AI agents

Finding a gem in a haystack



Amir Joudaki

October 12, 2026

01 · THE PROBLEM

Smart models fail beautifully.

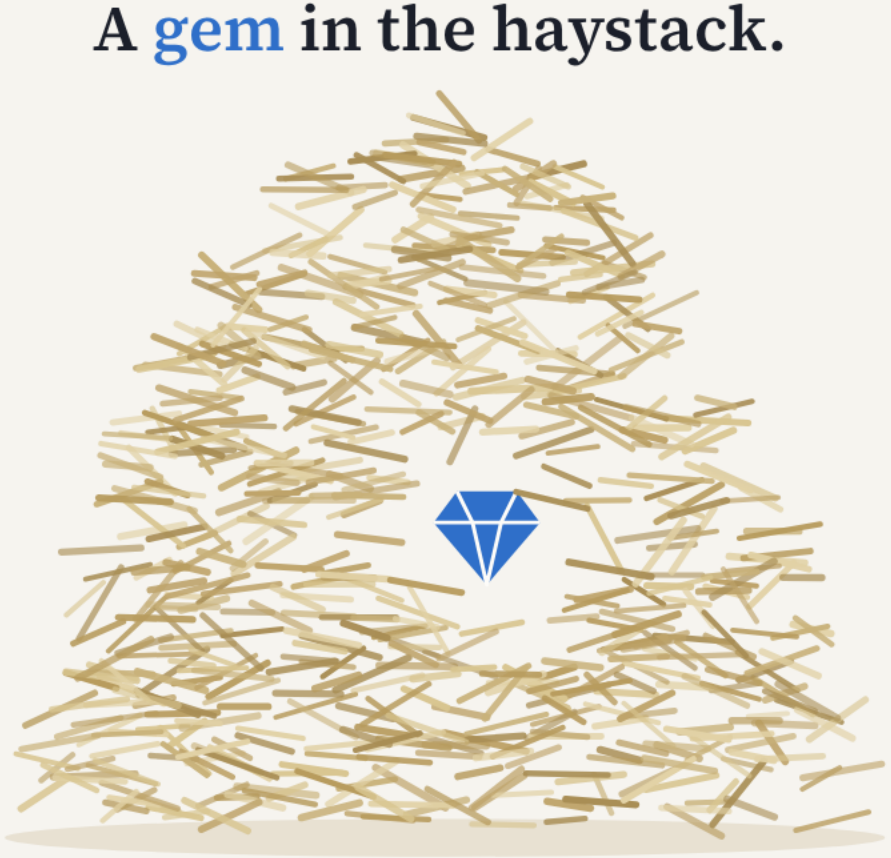
A gem in the haystack.



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1 More and more research goes to capable models.



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1 More and more research goes to capable models.

2 It fails silently: one hidden assumption sinks it.

3 More output than we can check: you're the bottleneck.

A gem in the haystack.





How do we find the gem?

02 · THE STRATEGY

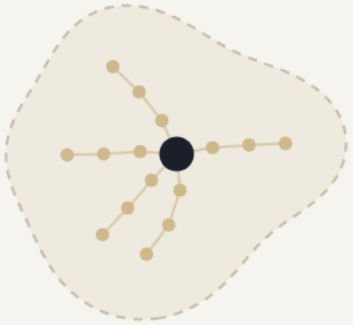
The strategy at a glance.

Open-ended question
where every thrust starts



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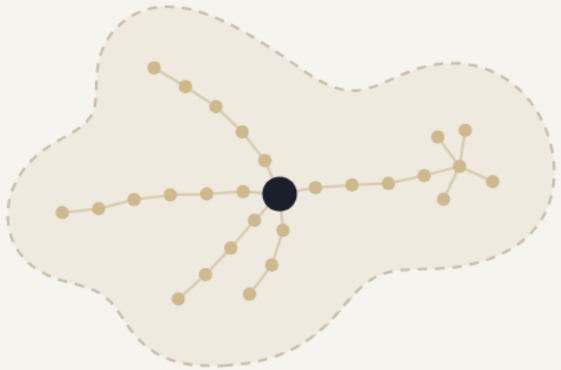


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Research thrusts
fresh exploration, pushed forward

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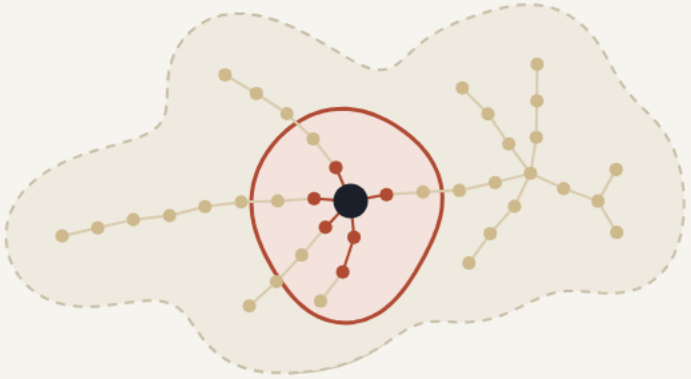


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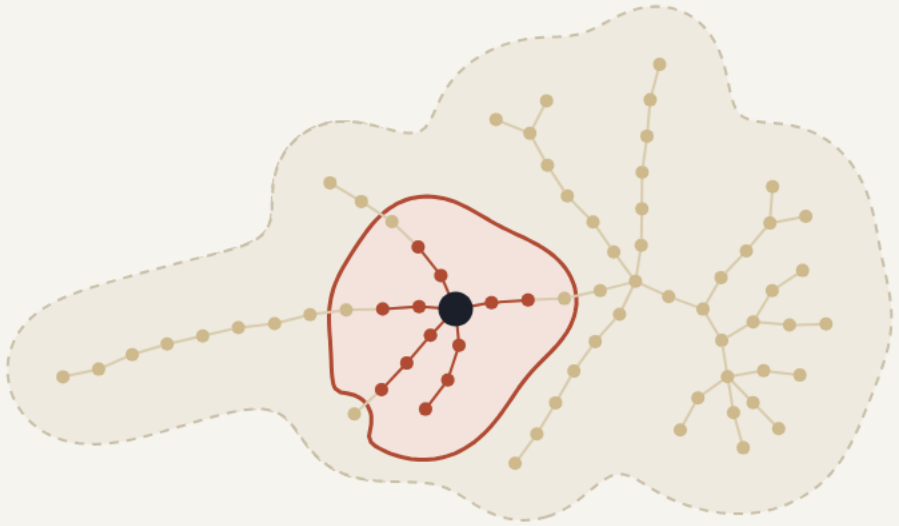
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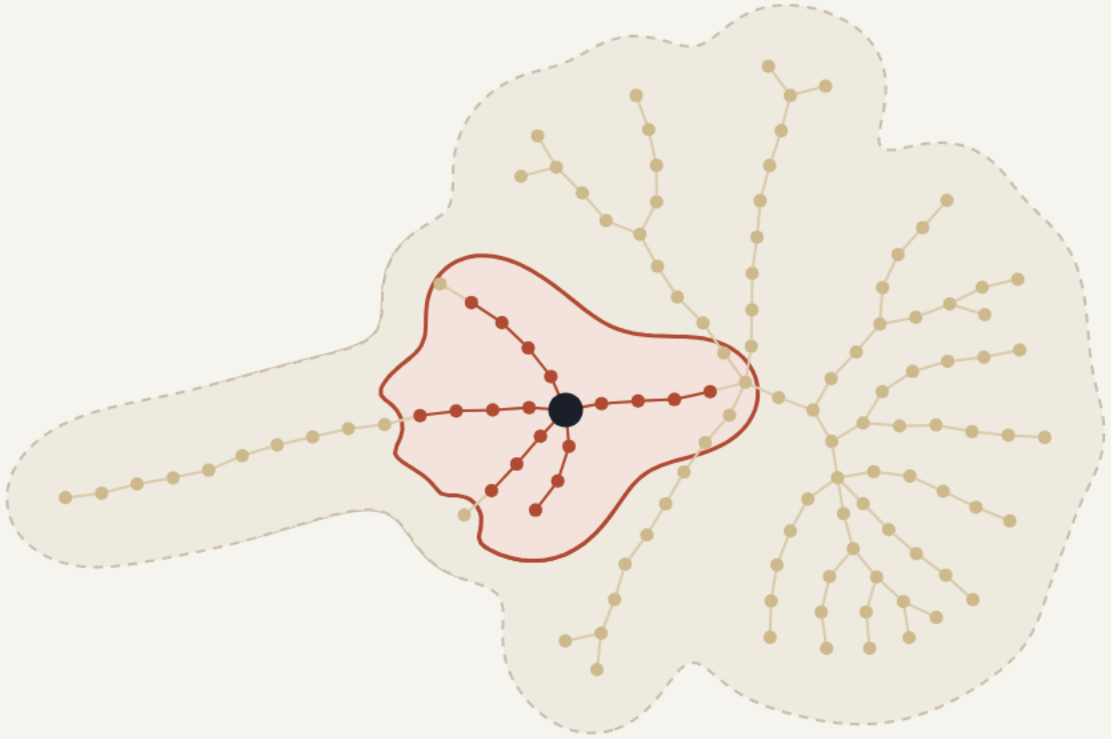
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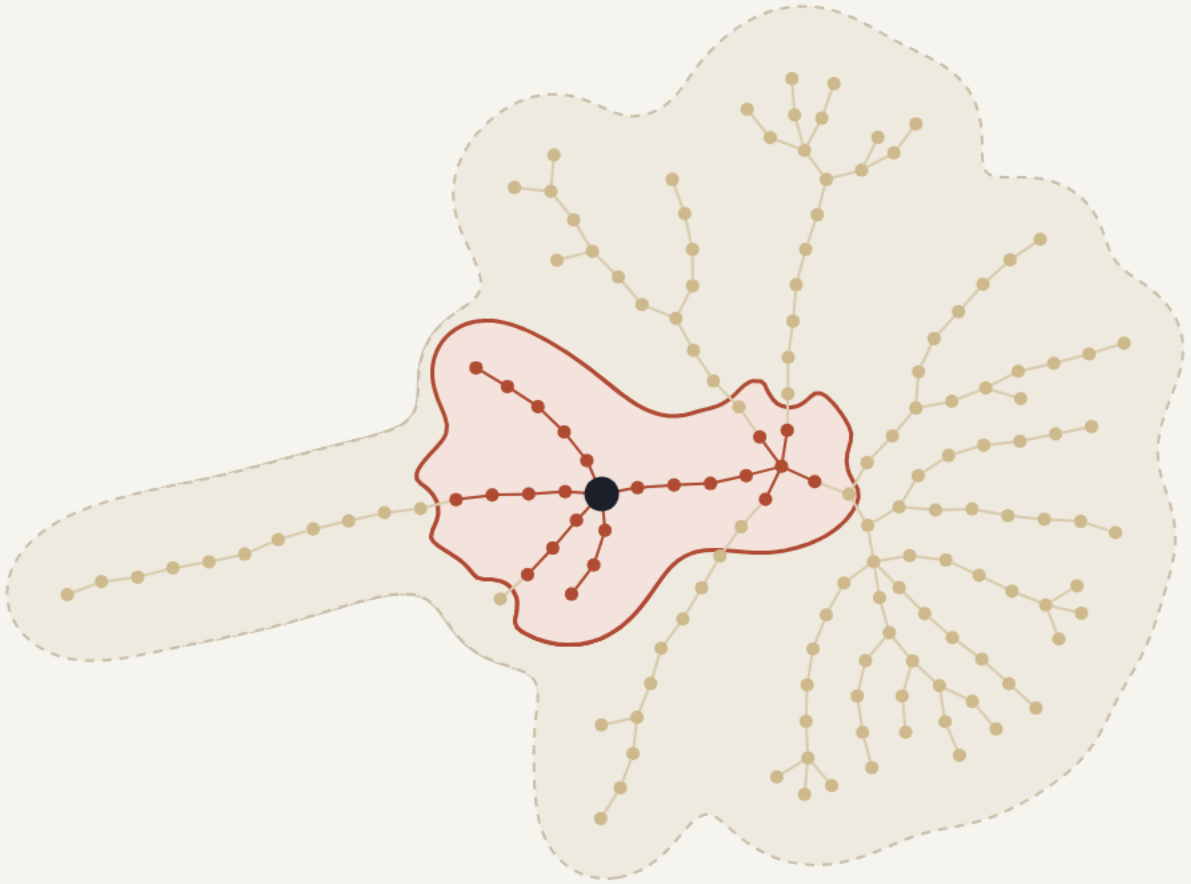
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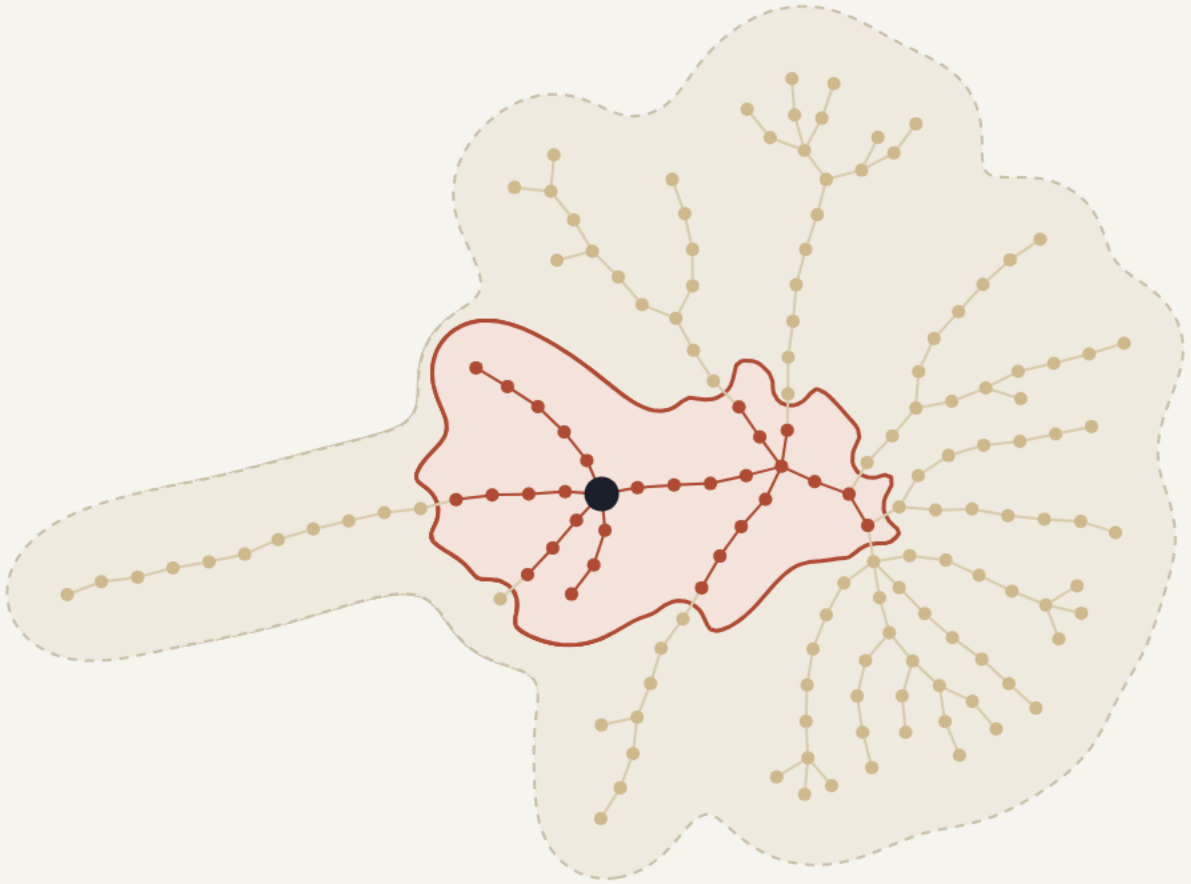
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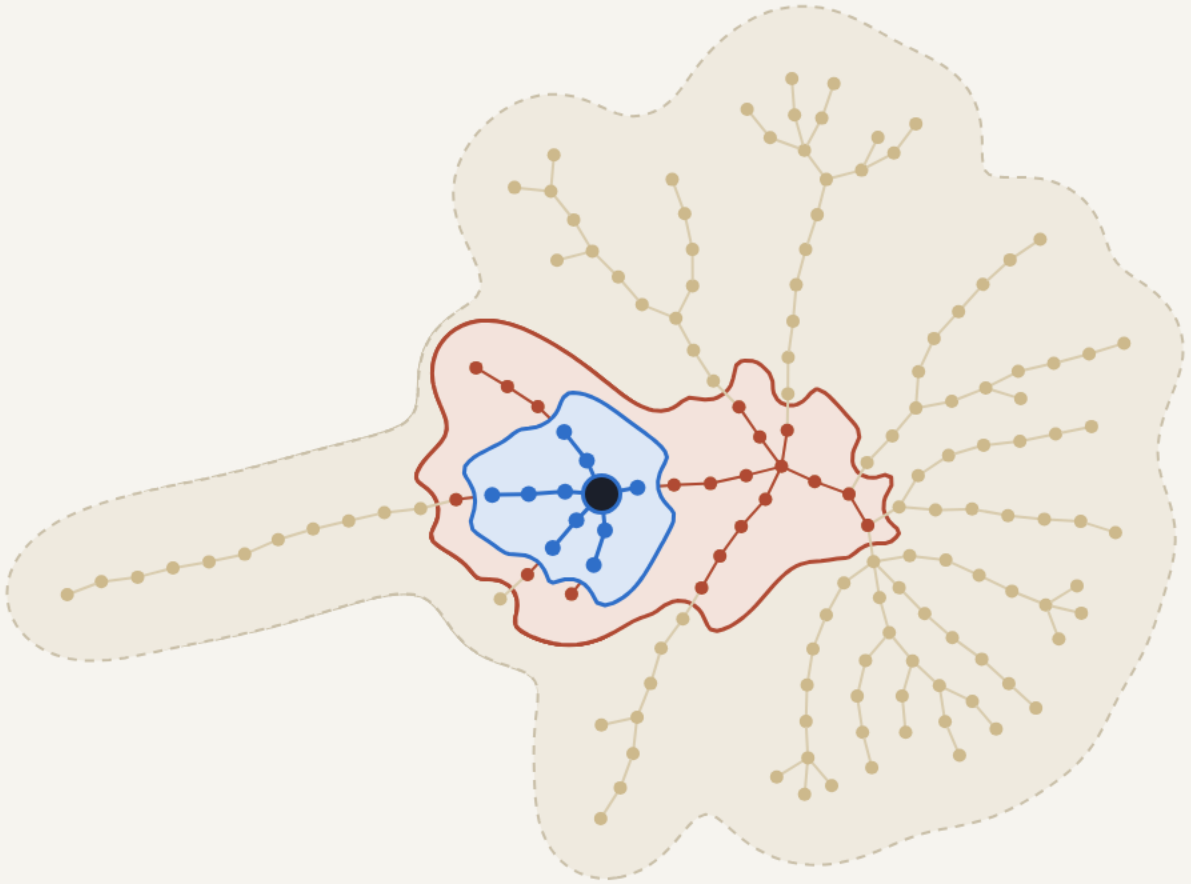
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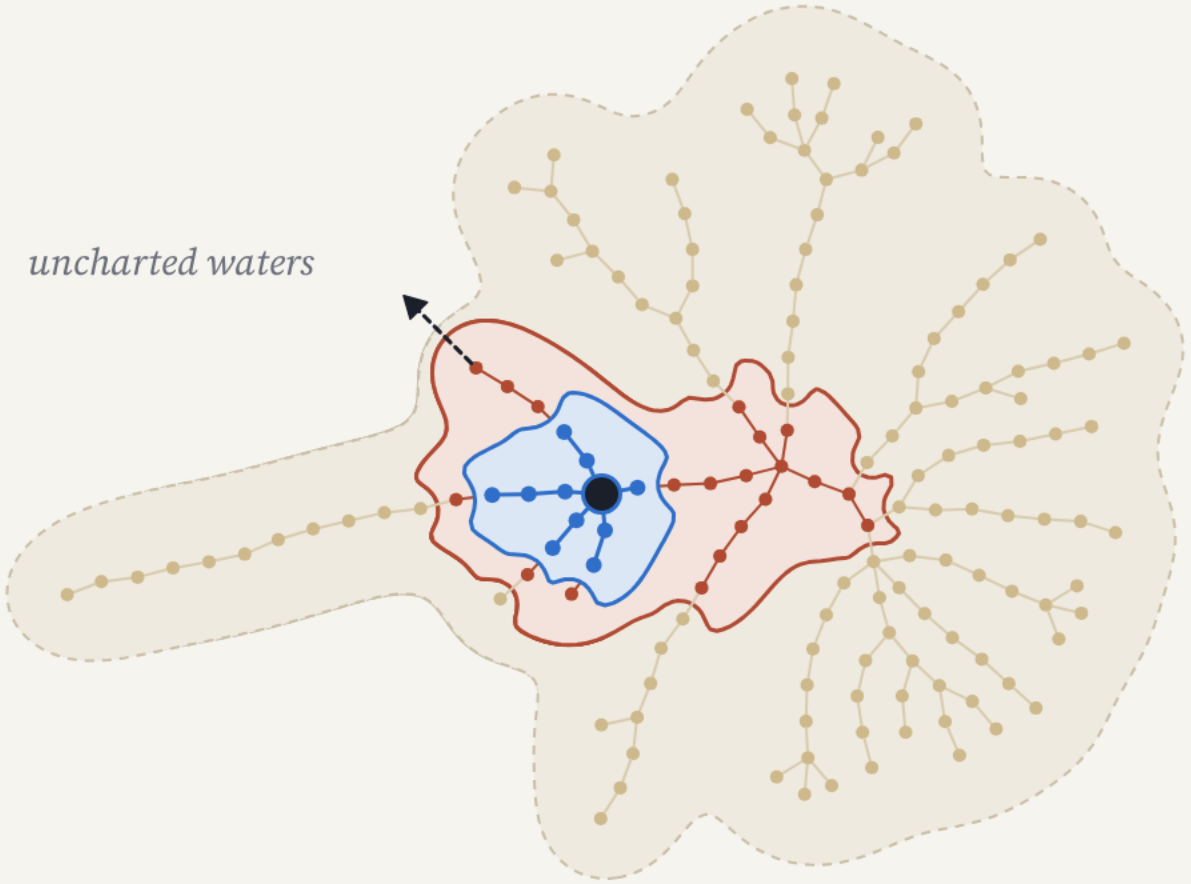
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The gem: a paper
carved out, audited for novelty, significance

That's the gem in the haystack.

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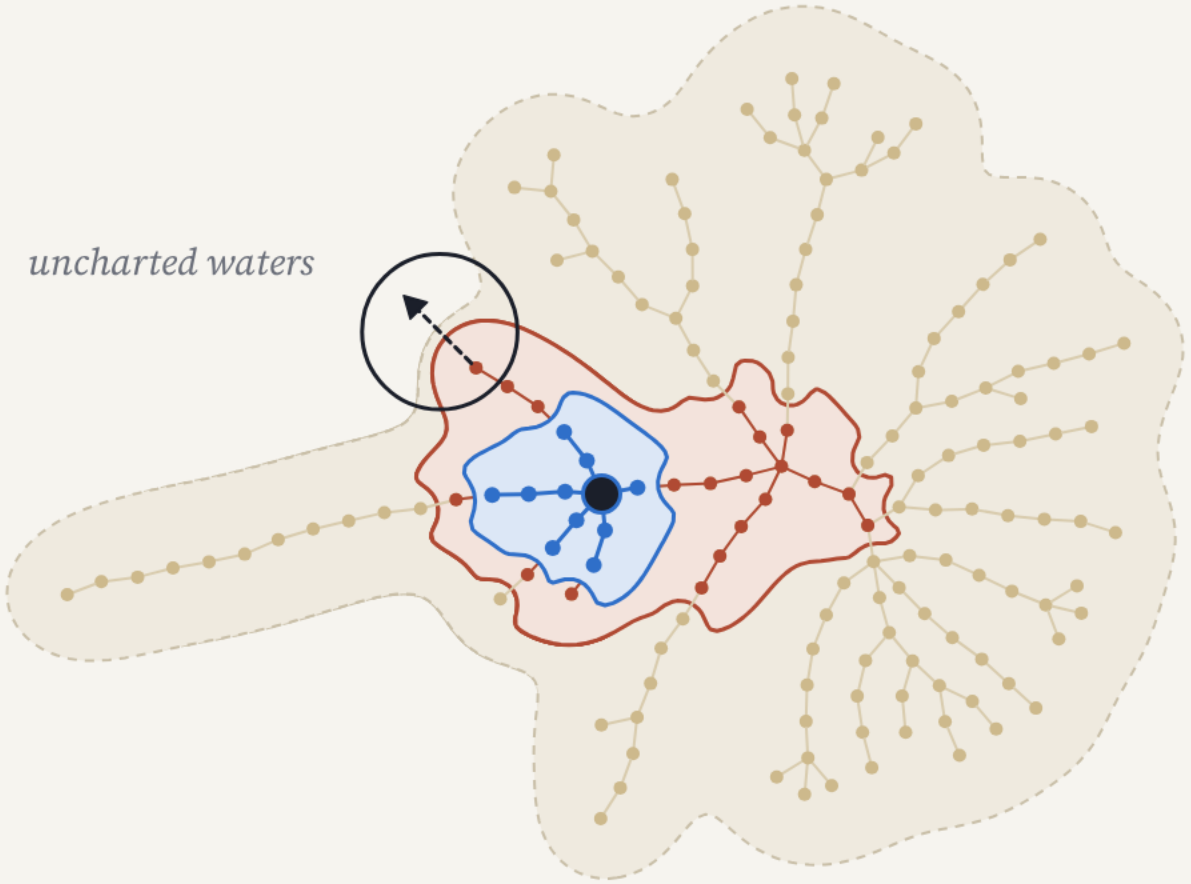
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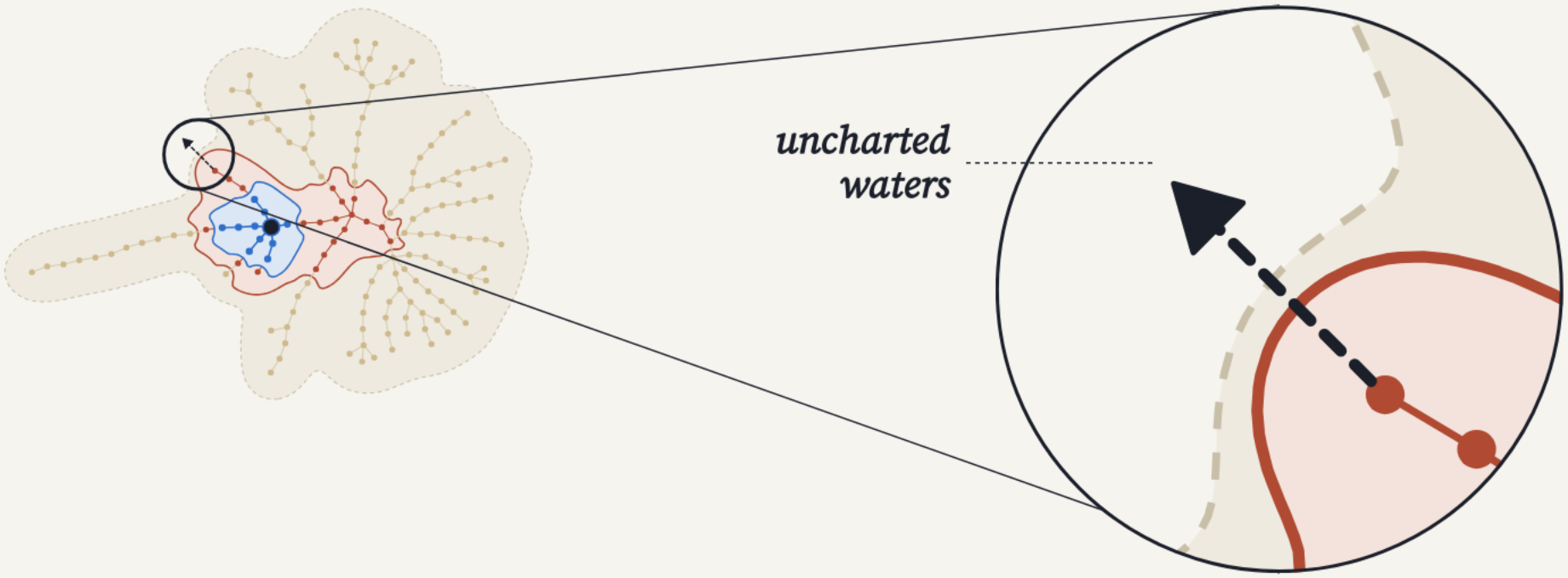
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How do we make each push succeed?

03 · INSIDE ONE THRUST

The multi-agent engine behind every thrust.

ONE THREAD
Why one long thread fails

INDEPENDENCE
Fresh agents, different angles

OPPOSITION
An author and a critic

COST
A pyramid, and cheap checks

Many agents, well organized, make the push feasible.

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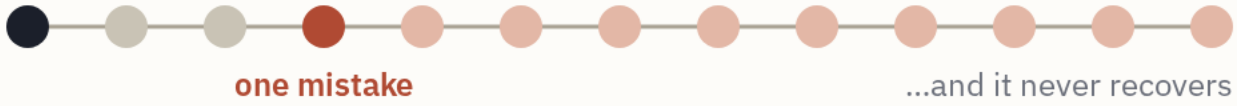
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· Every dead end piles into one context
· An early mistake anchors the rest
· “Be unbiased” can't undo it

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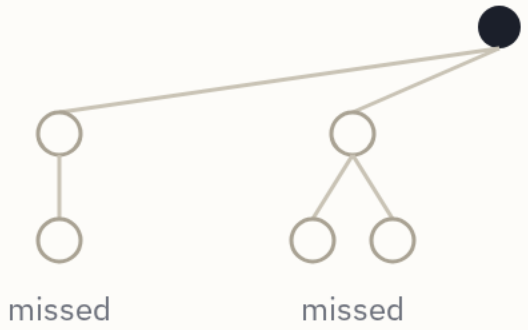
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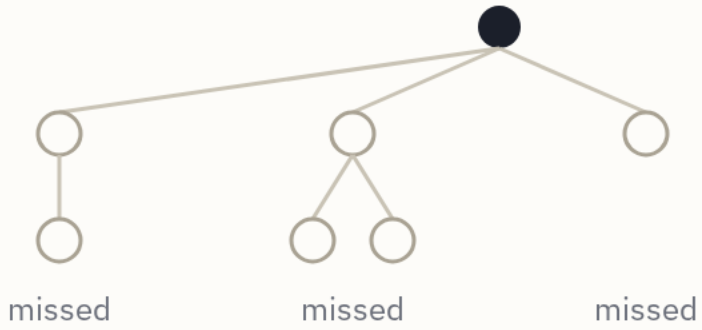
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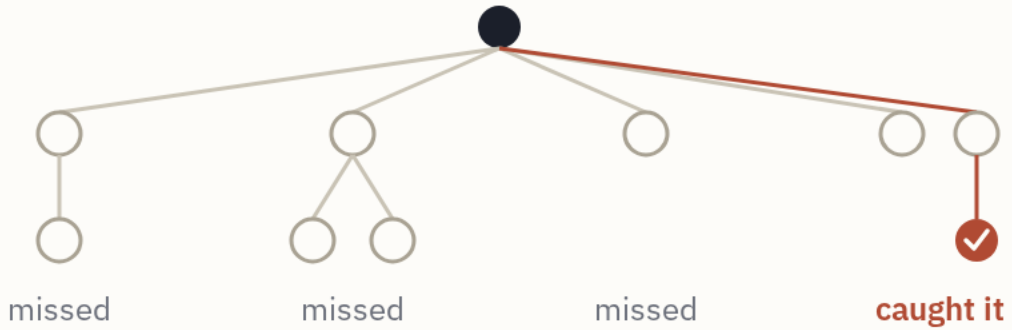
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· Each starts clean, sees only its folder
· Several miss; one catch is enough
· Skills: parallel proof routes, gate reviews

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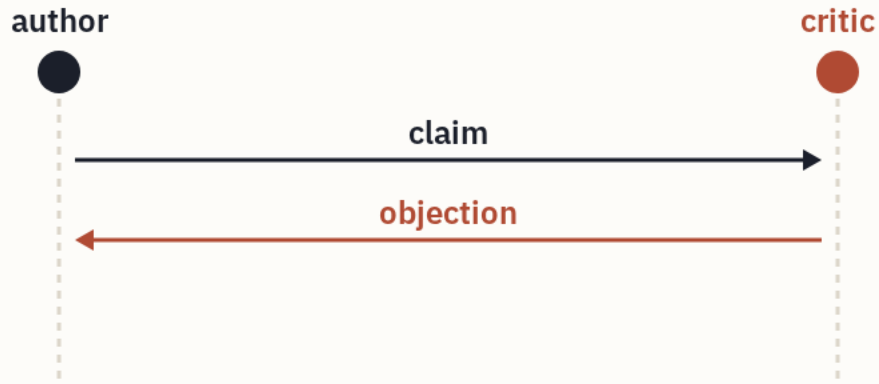
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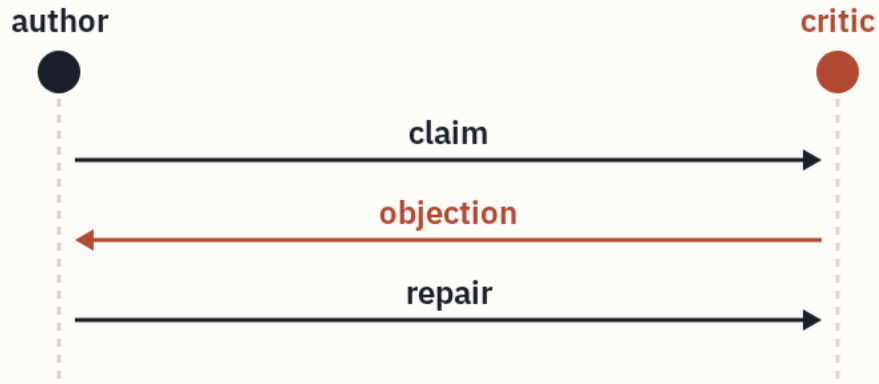
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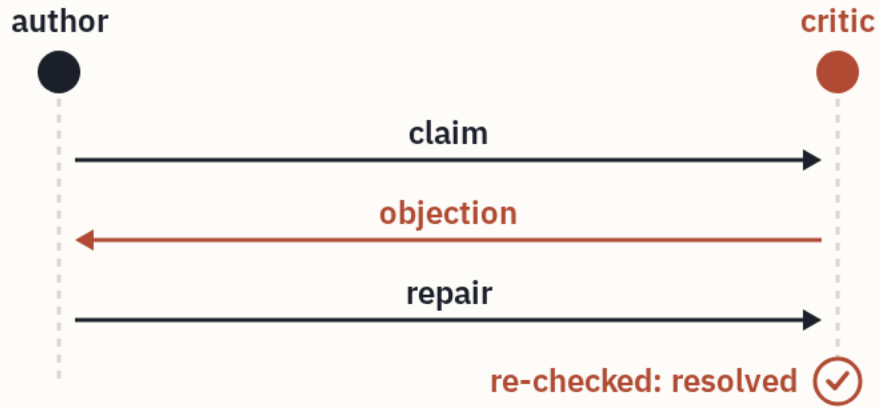
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· Opposing roles, round after round
· Skills: the hostile audit in formulate-problem
· A fresh review after every fix

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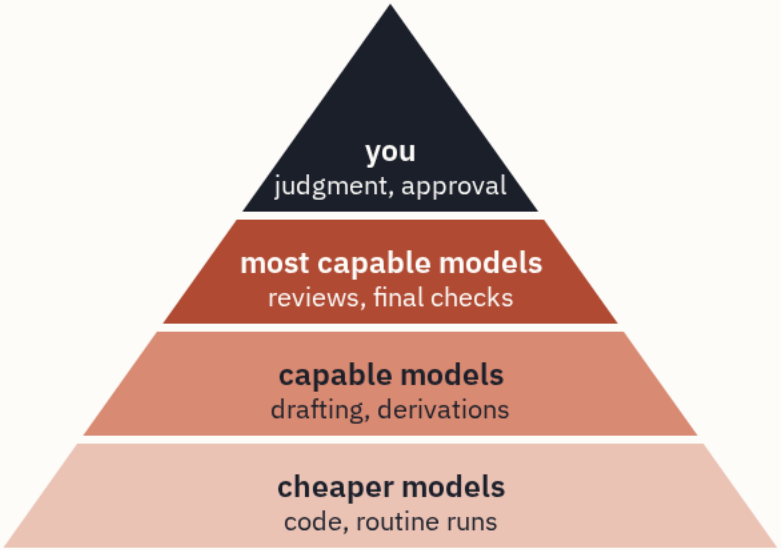
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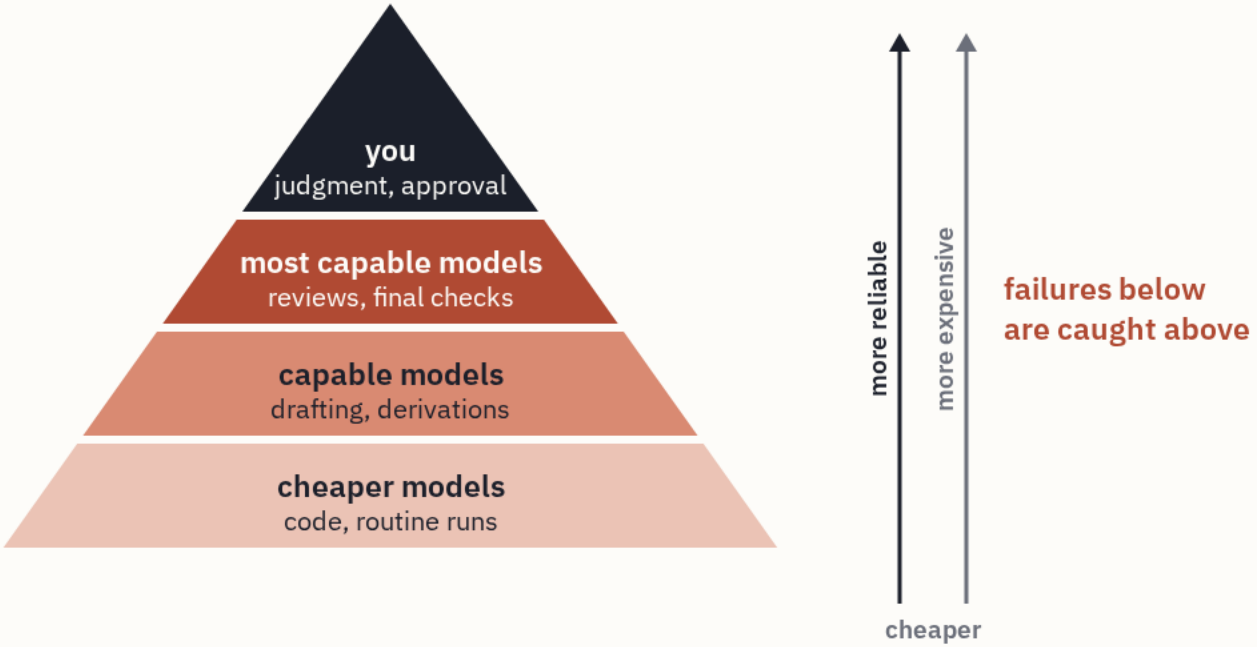
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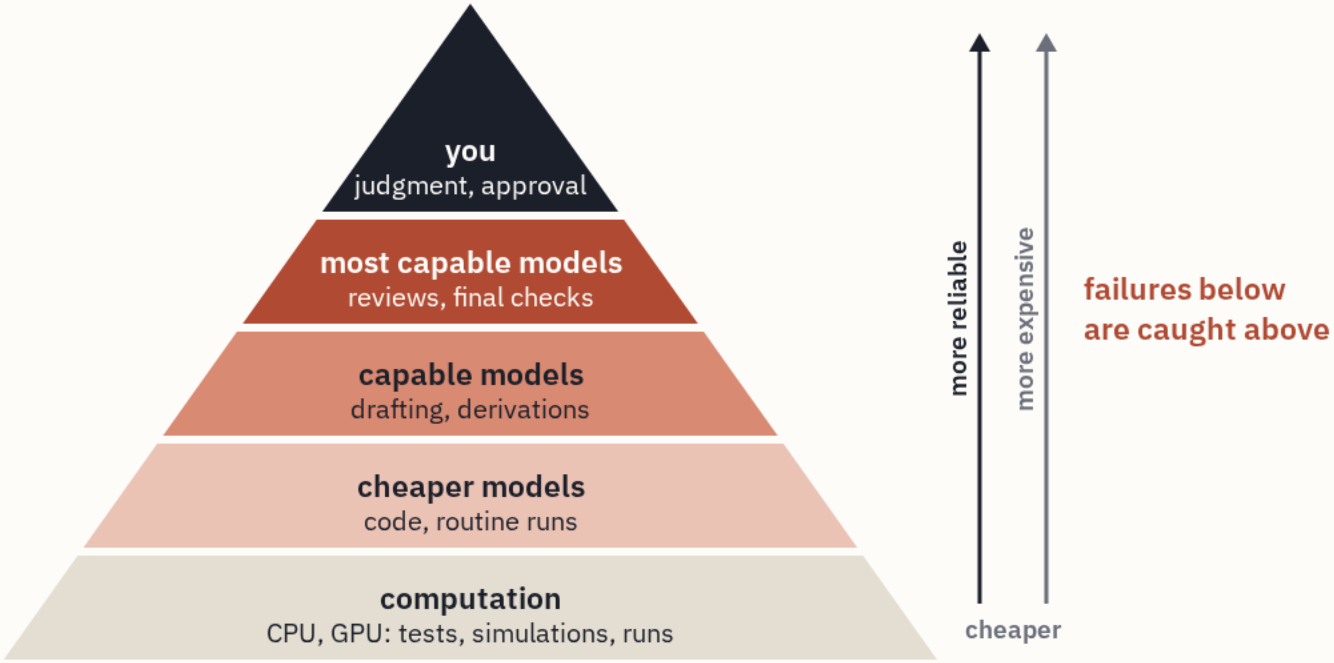
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How do we do this in practice?

04 · THE FOUNDATIONS

Three foundations that make it practical.

CONTEXT

A coding agent on one workstation

PERSISTENCE

Everything under version control

REUSE

Projects and skills

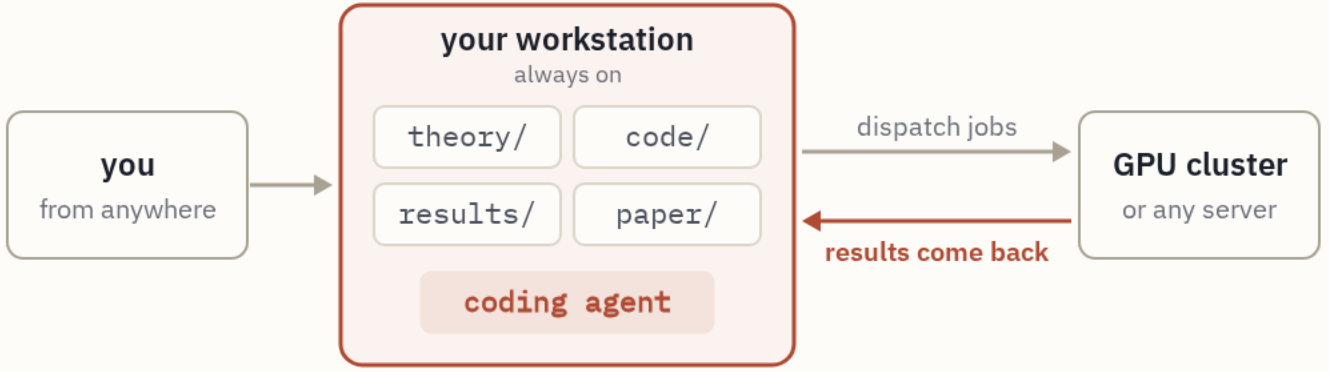
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CONTEXT: EVERYTHING IN ONE PLACE



- A coding agent, not a chat
- Theory, code, results, paper: all in reach
- Works overnight, waits for runs

Three foundations that make it practical.

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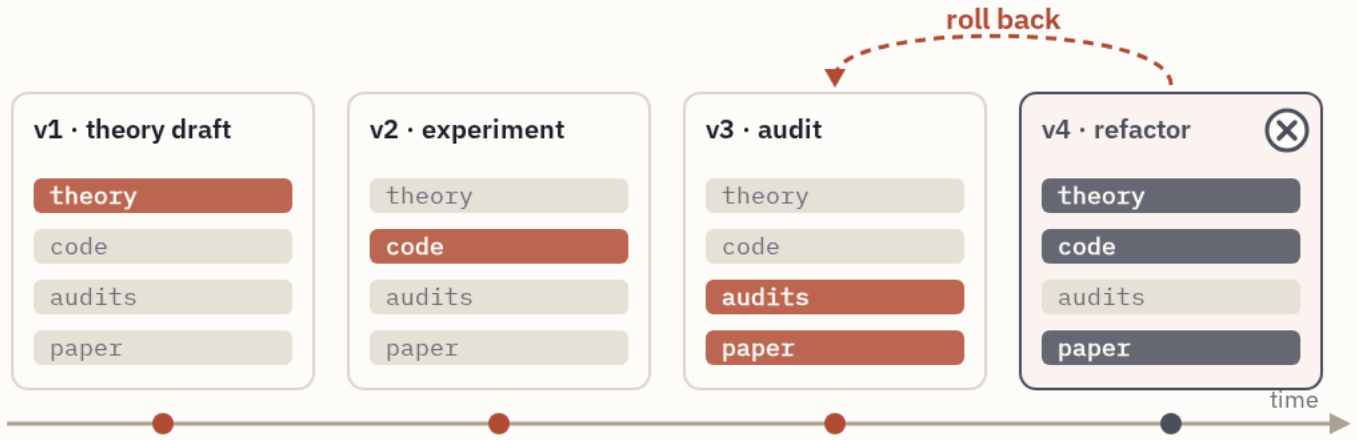
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PERSISTENCE: EVERY SNAPSHOT HOLDS EVERYTHING



· Not just code: theory, audits, paper

· Roll back a bad agent or decision

· Big refactors become safe

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REUSE: PROJECTS AND SKILLS



- A project: a folder with shared rules
- Skills are plain files: portable across models
- Everything in this repo is a skill

Everything from here is a skill.

05 · FIVE SKILLS

Five skills: from open-ended question to paper.

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A whole project
one big, open question

ORGANIZE

`organize-research-project`

Many thrusts → one core

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↓ every thrust runs these three

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Result → understood

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the core becomes a paper →

AUDIT
`review-paper`
Paper → rigorous audit

↺ findings start the next round

↓ every thrust runs these three

Each thrust
one targeted question

FORMULATE
`formulate-problem`
Open → precise question

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Organize: isolated thrusts, a gated core.



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Own question, inputs and folder; blind to the others by default.

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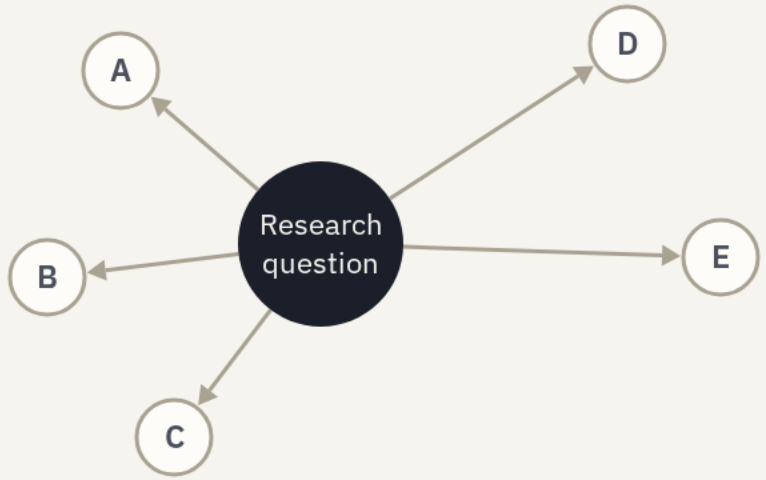


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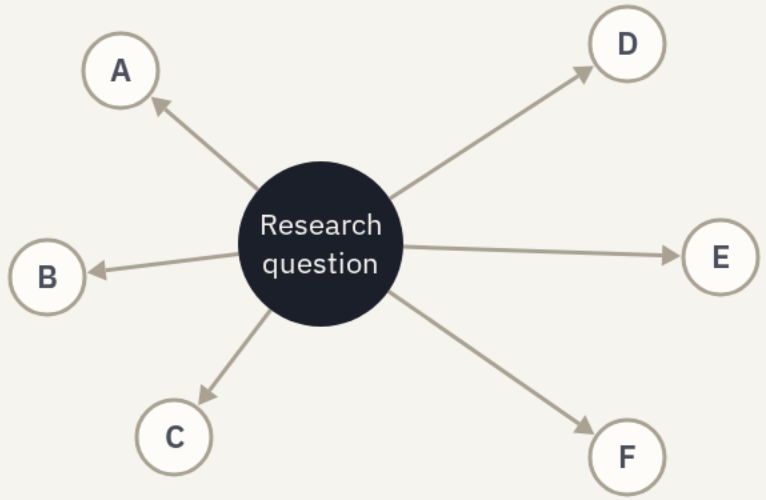


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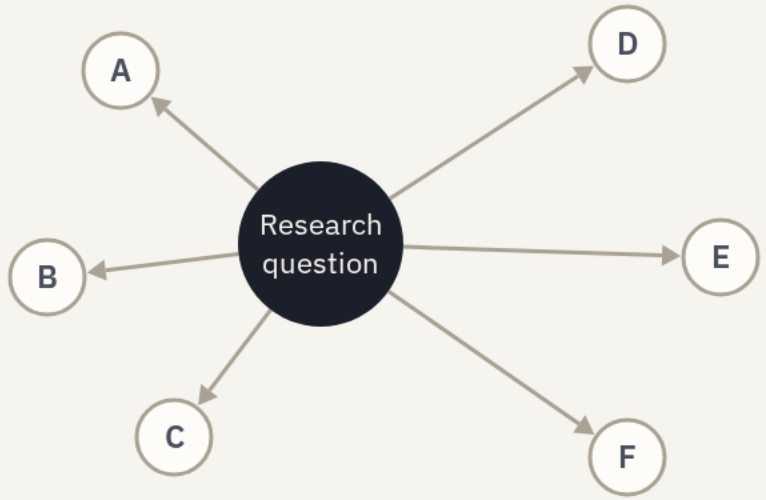
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2 Established core

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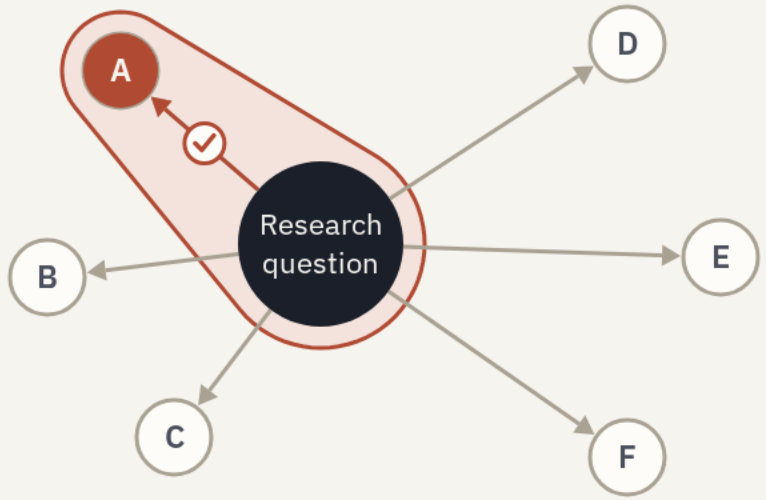
Correct: an independent review

Coherent: notation, interfaces, tests

Relevant: your approval

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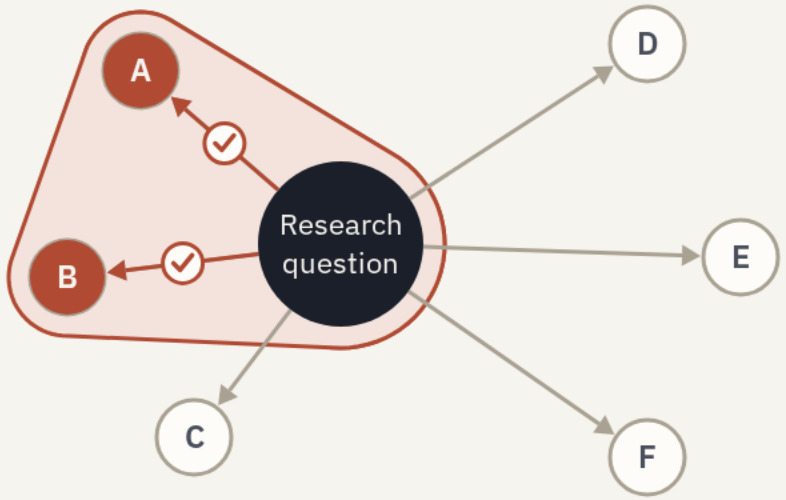
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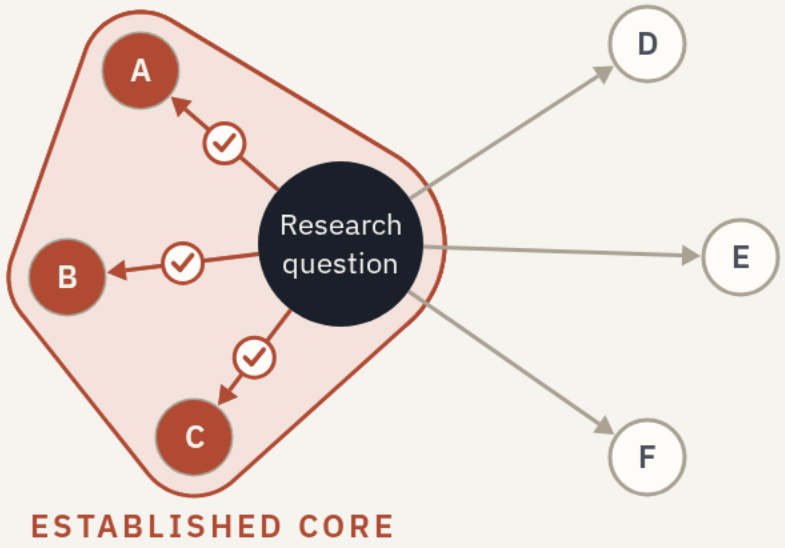
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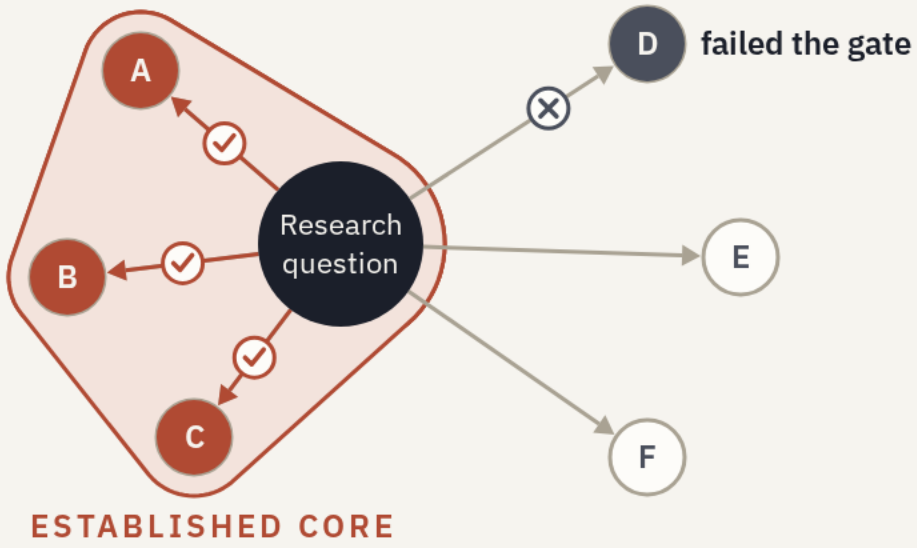
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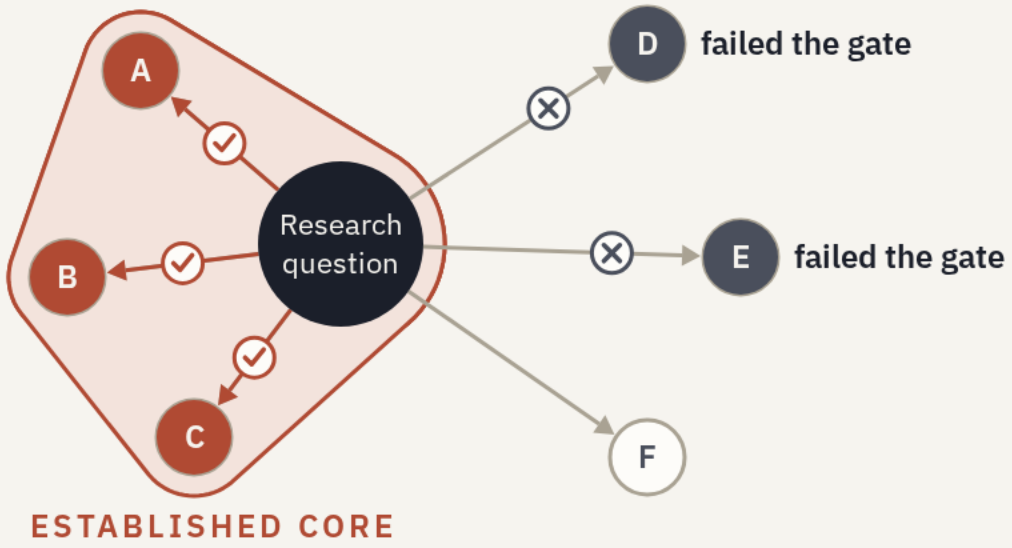
Correct: an independent review

Coherent: notation, interfaces, tests

Relevant: your approval

`organize-research-project`

Organize: isolated thrusts, a gated core.



Inside each study: formulate, solve, learn.

1 Isolated studies

Own question, inputs and folder; blind to the others by default.

→ **the widest exploration**

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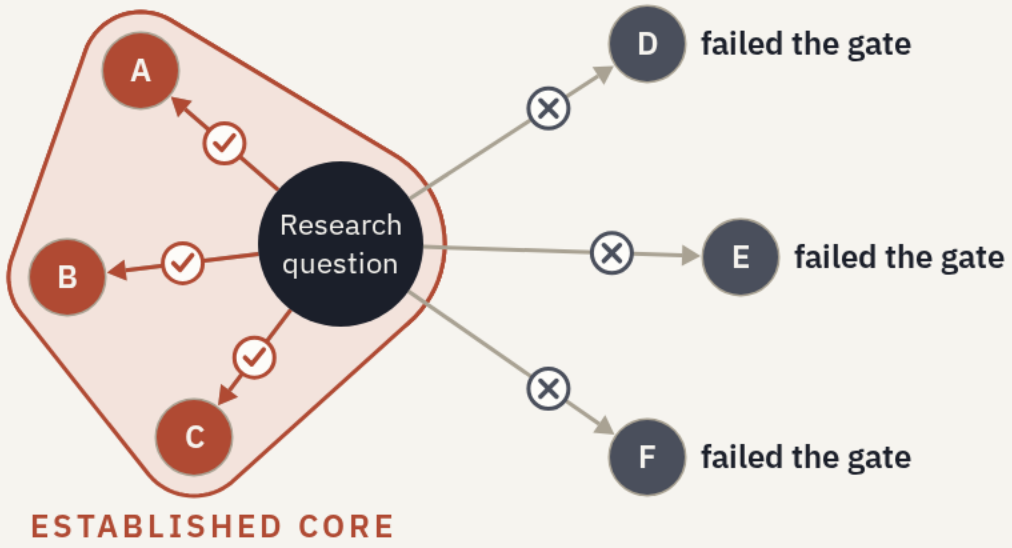
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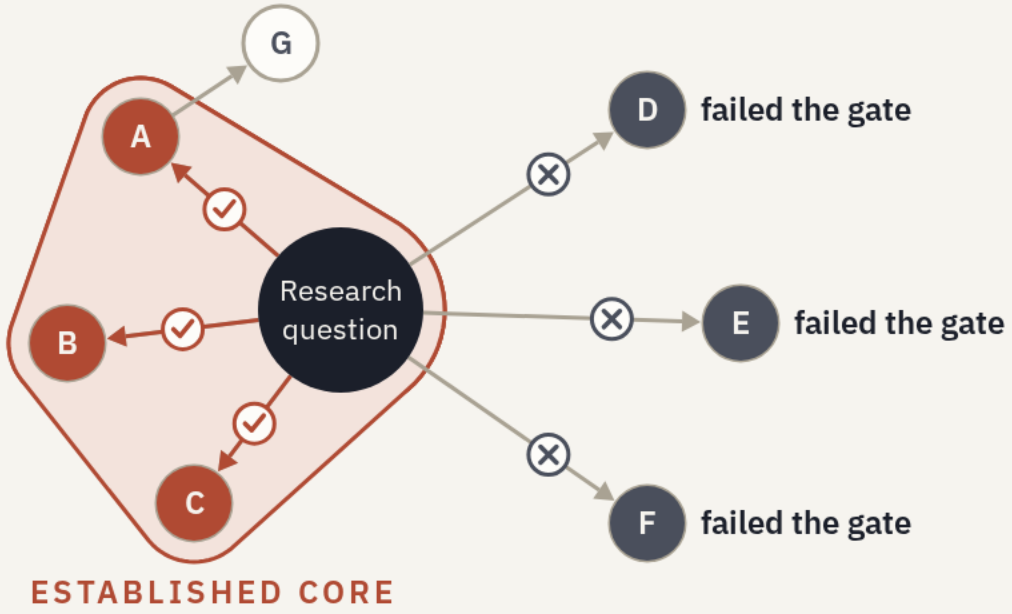
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→ **high signal-to-noise**

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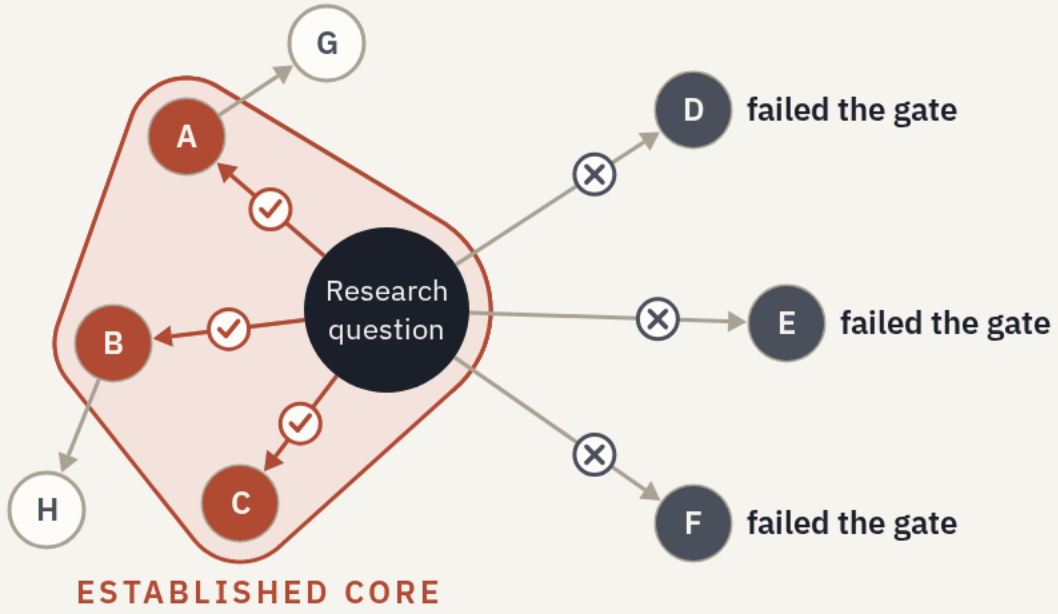
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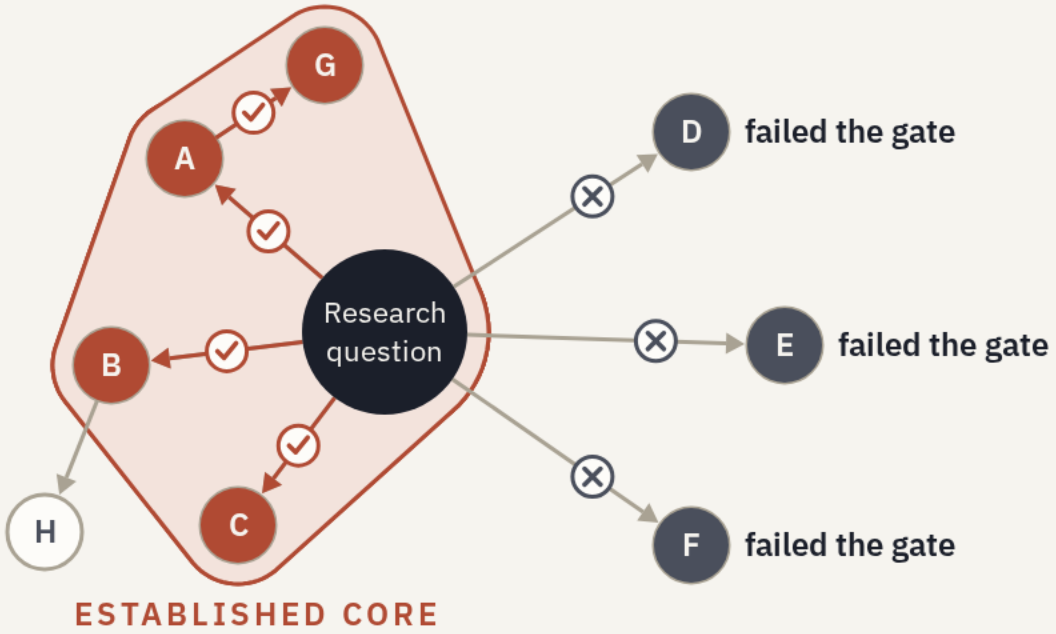
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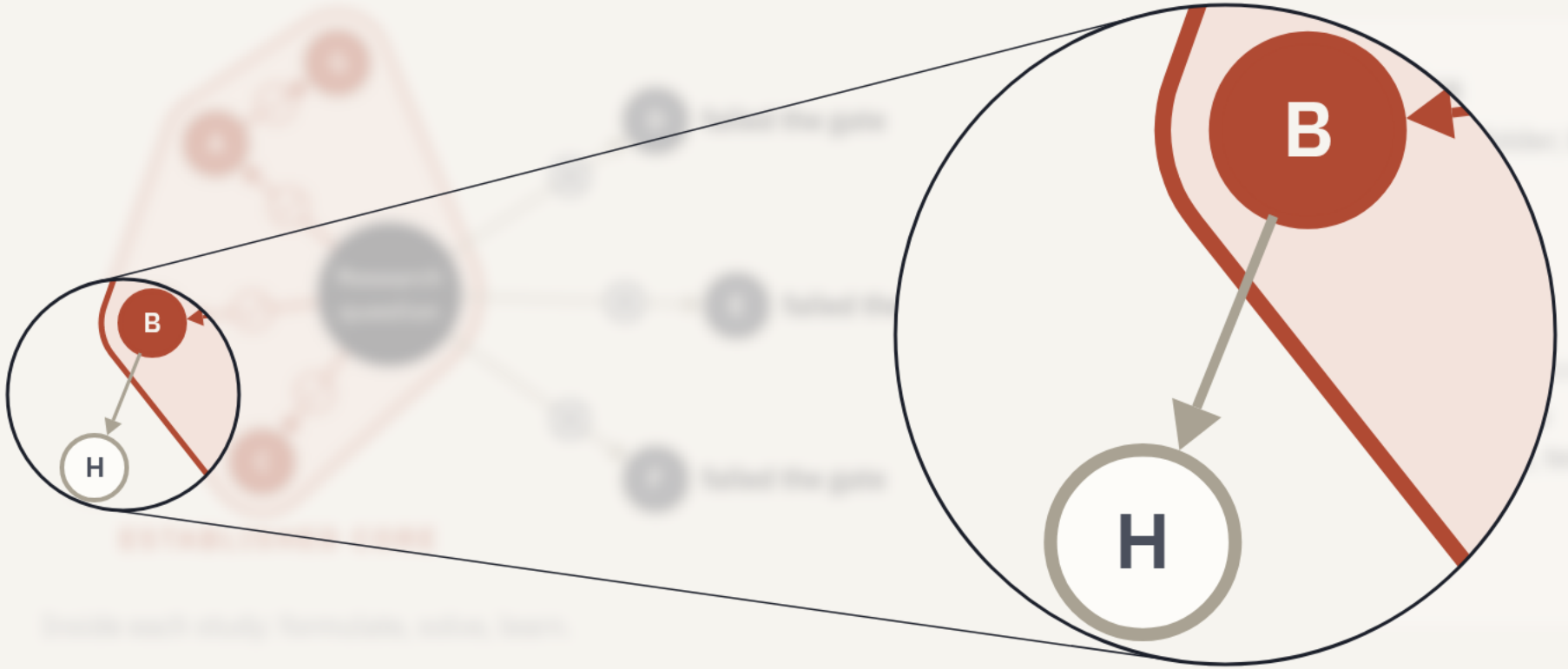
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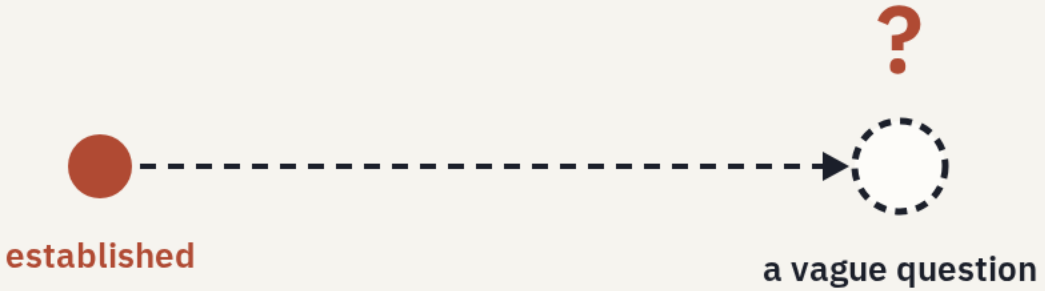
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organize-research-project

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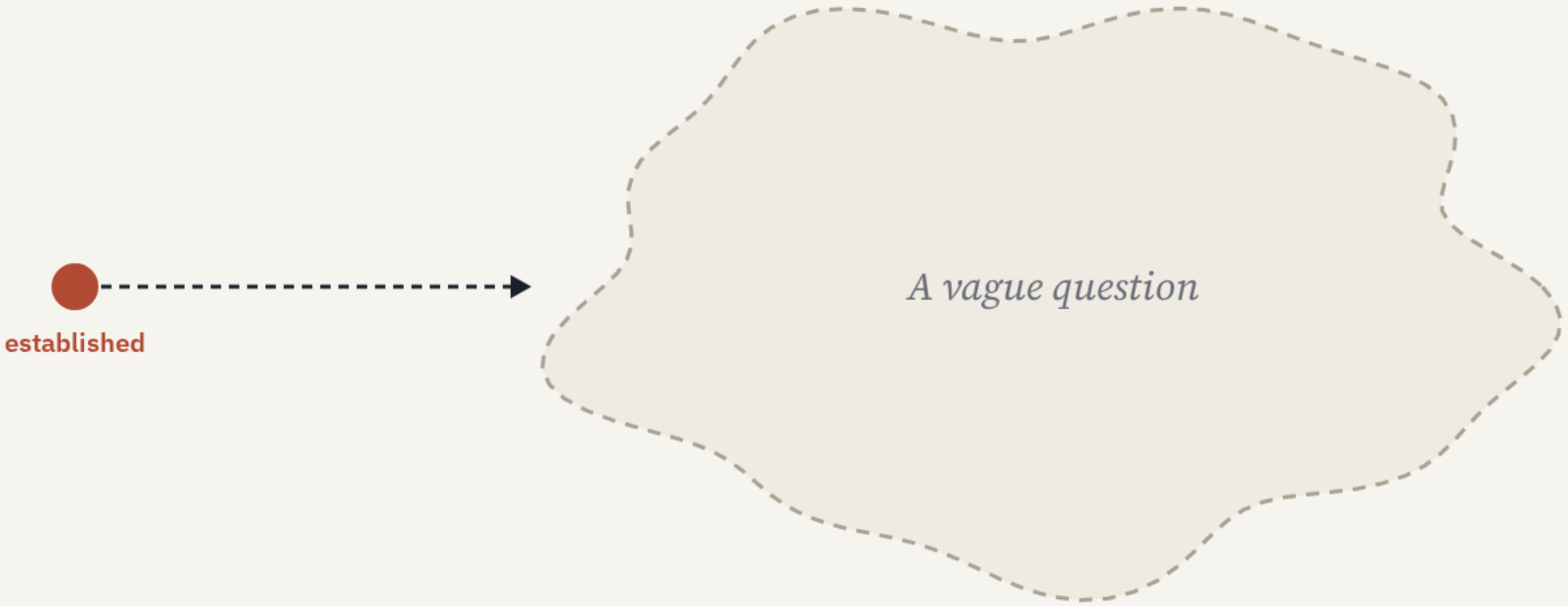
Each thrust is hard. How do we push through?



First, what exactly is the question?

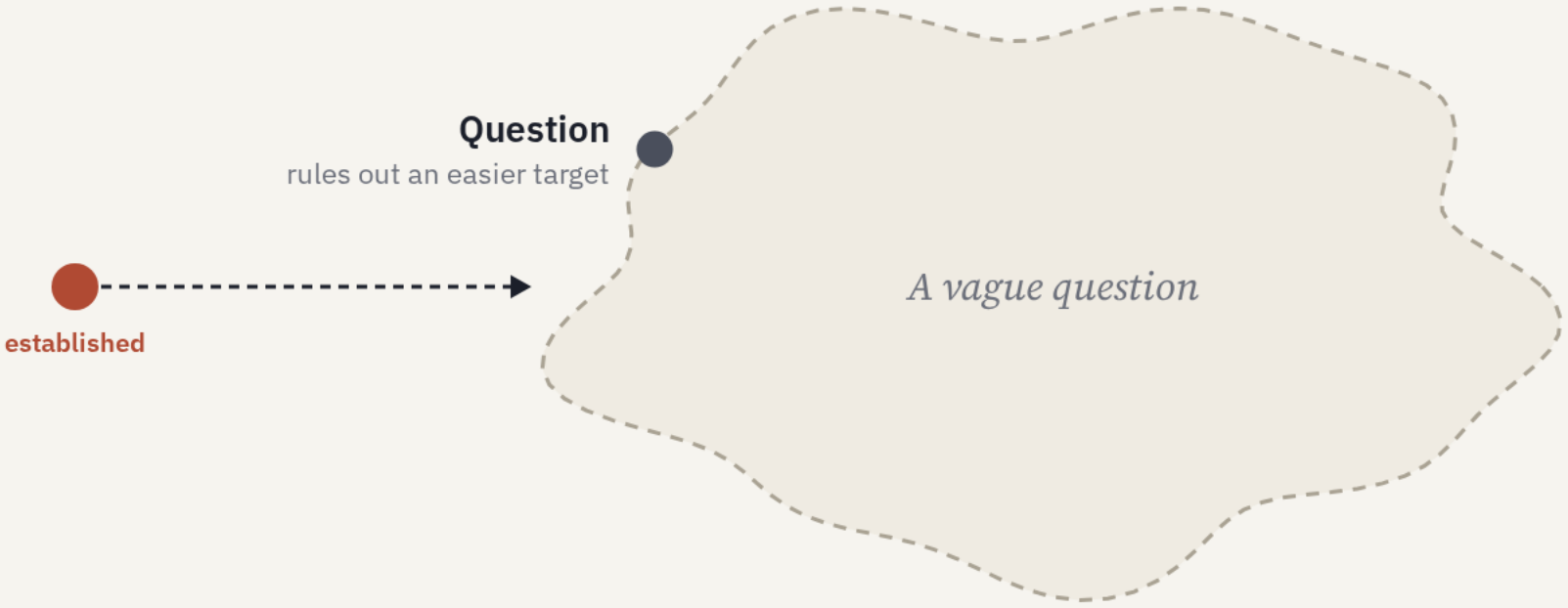
`formulate-problem`

Formulate the steelman, then freeze it.



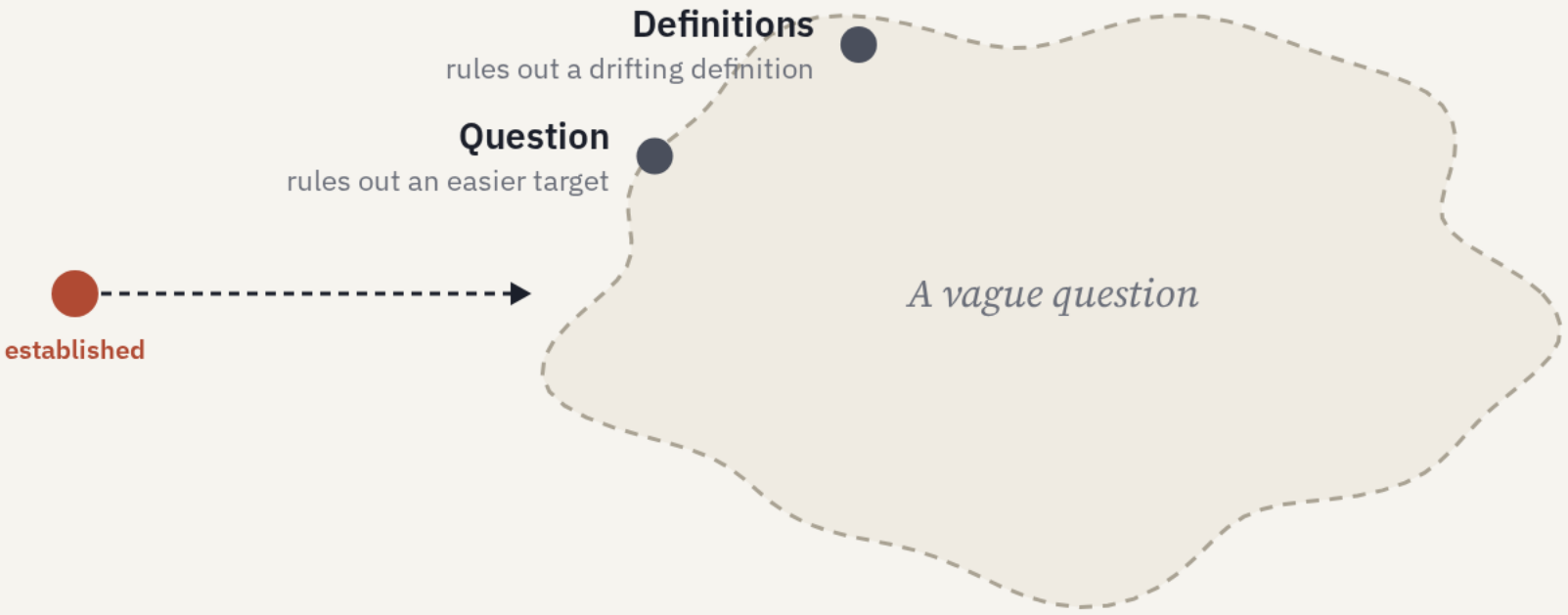
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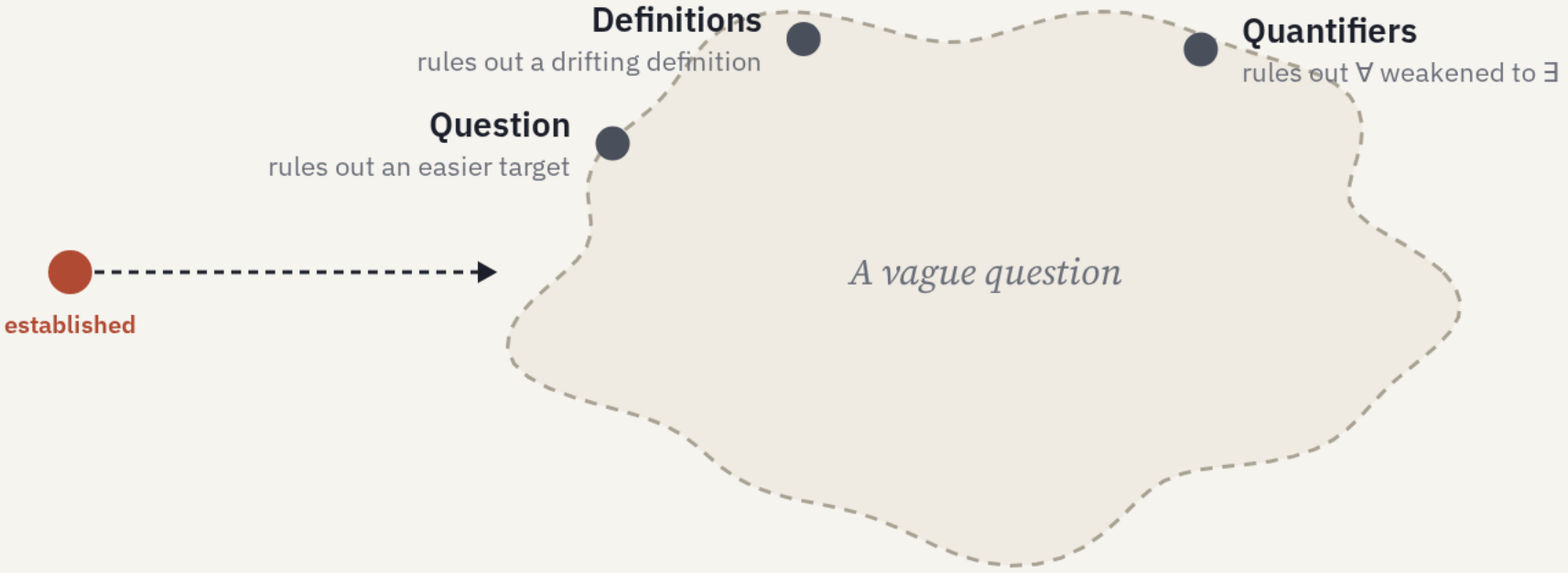
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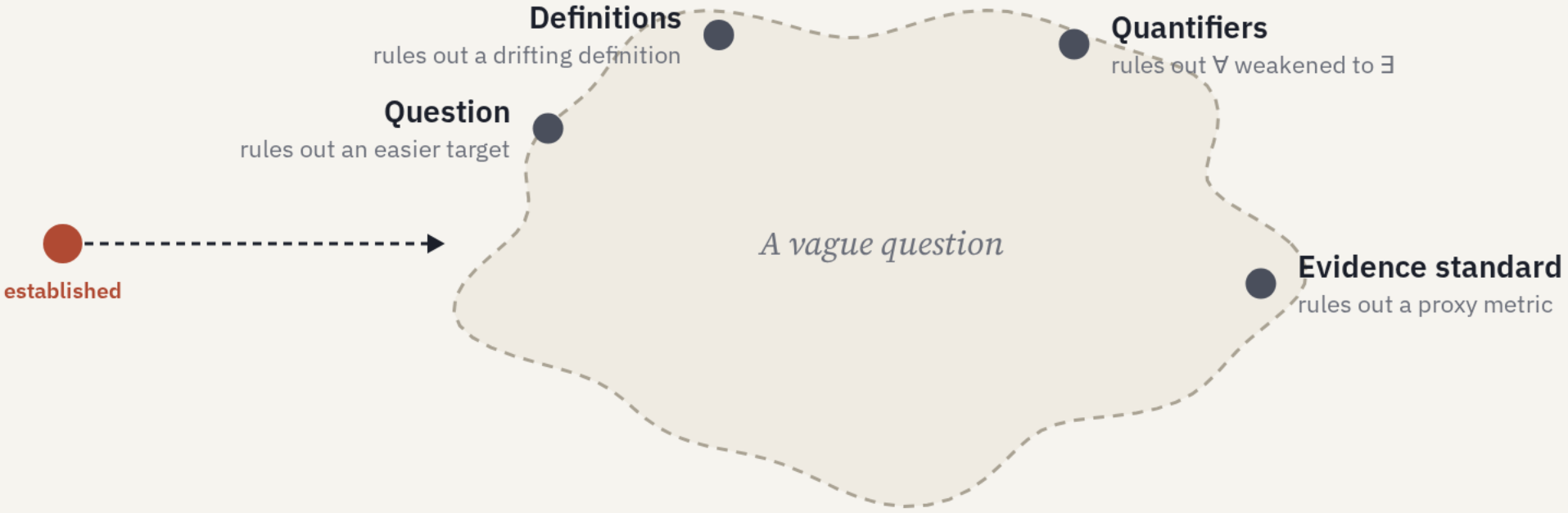
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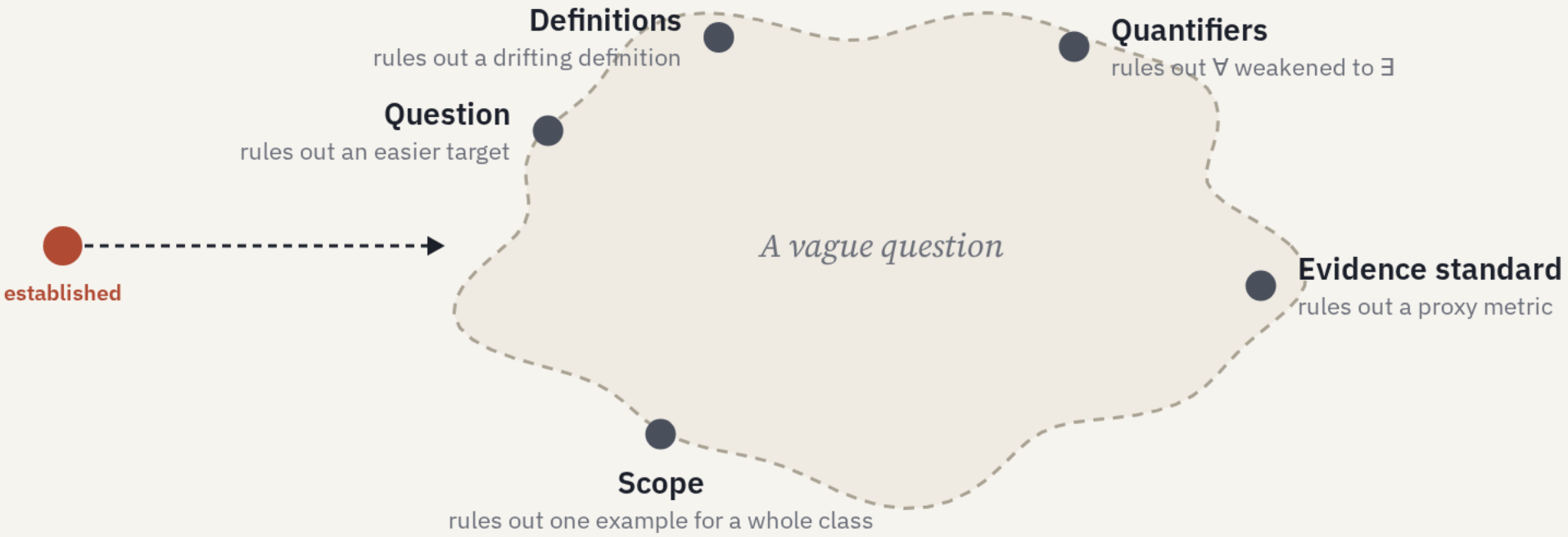
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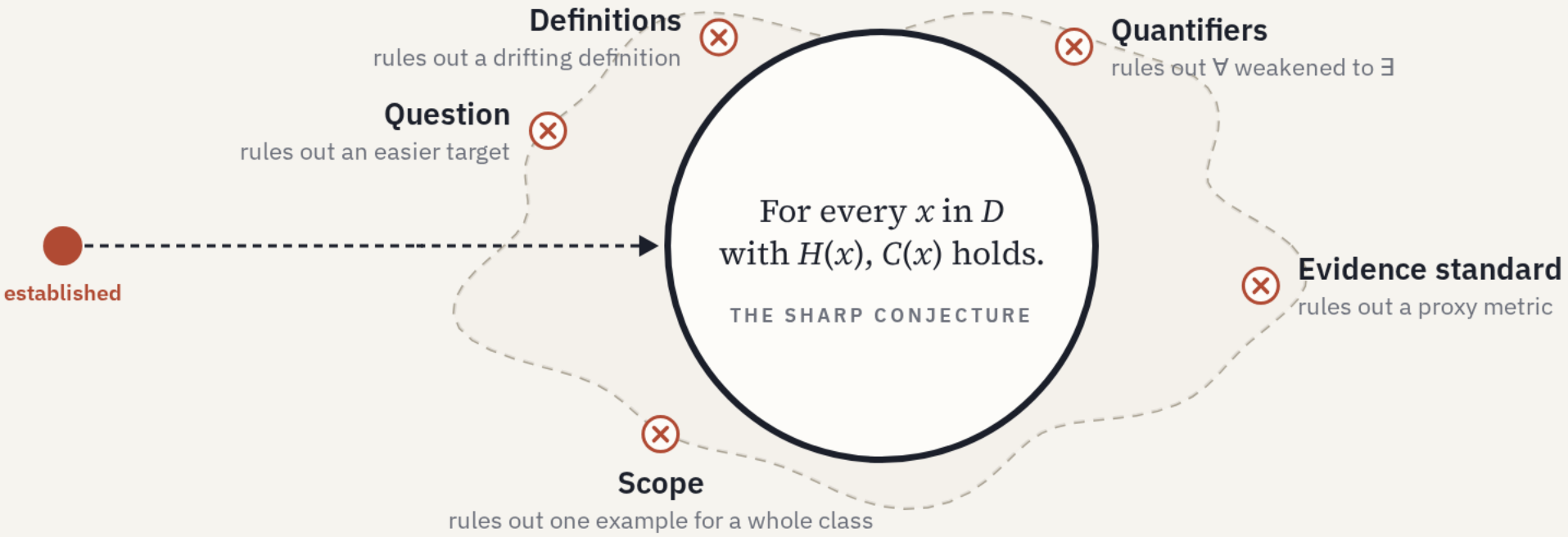
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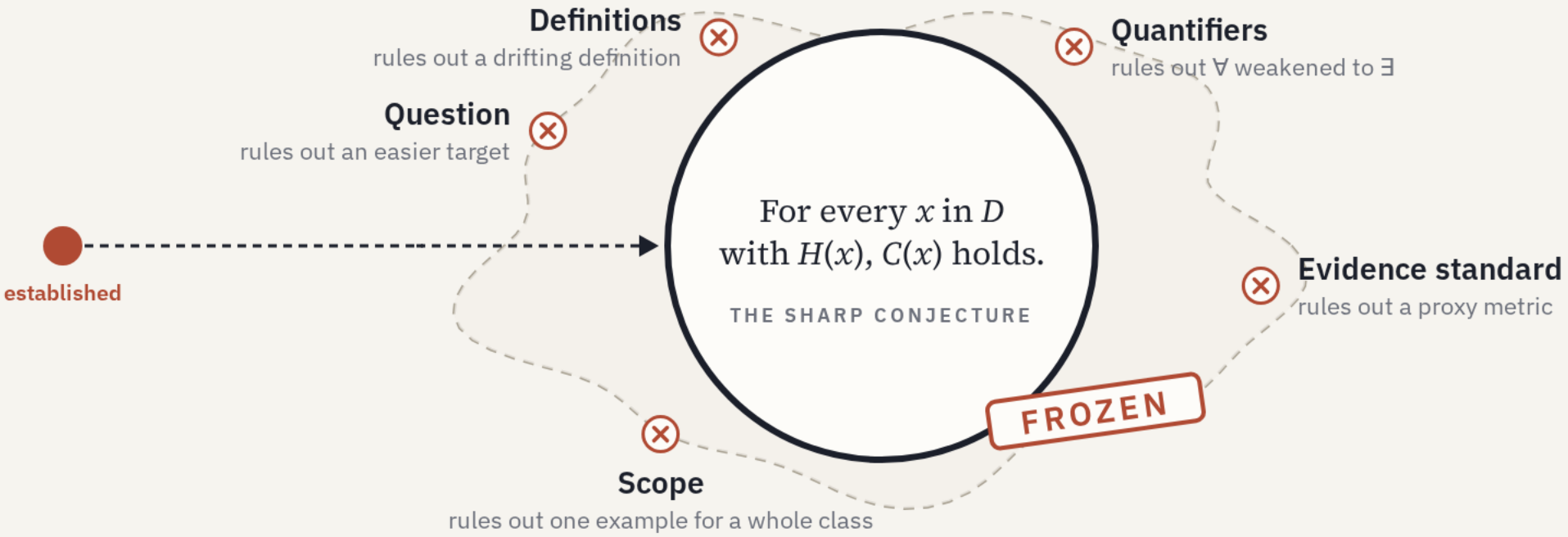
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Formulate the steelman, then freeze it.





Now, how do we solve it?

`solve-problem`

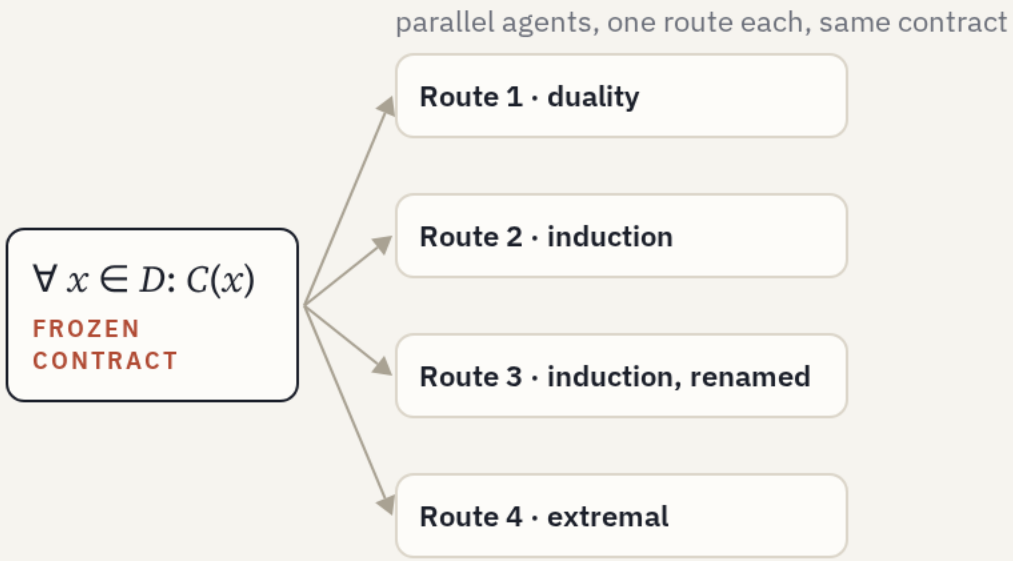
Solve by many routes, then audit the proof.

$\forall\, x \in D\colon C(x)$

FROZEN CONTRACT

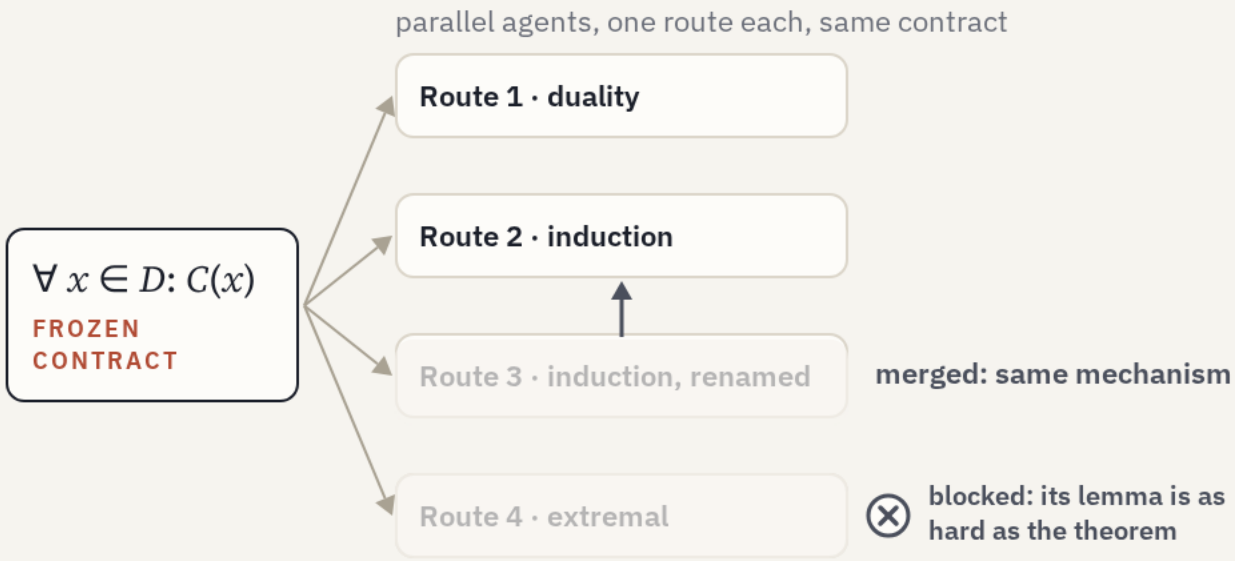
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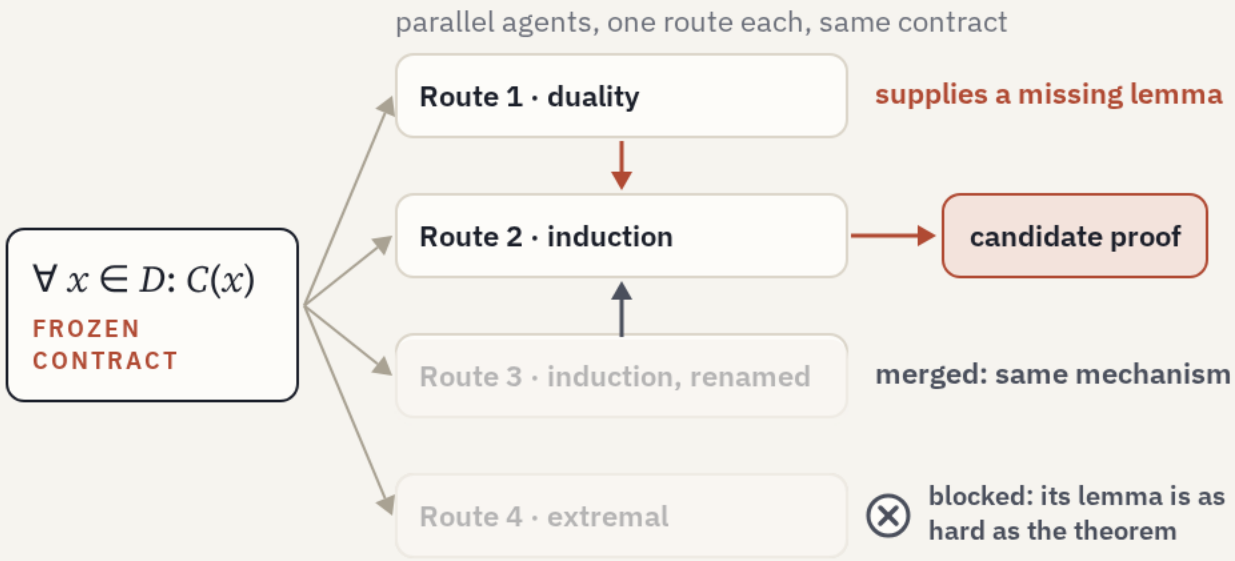
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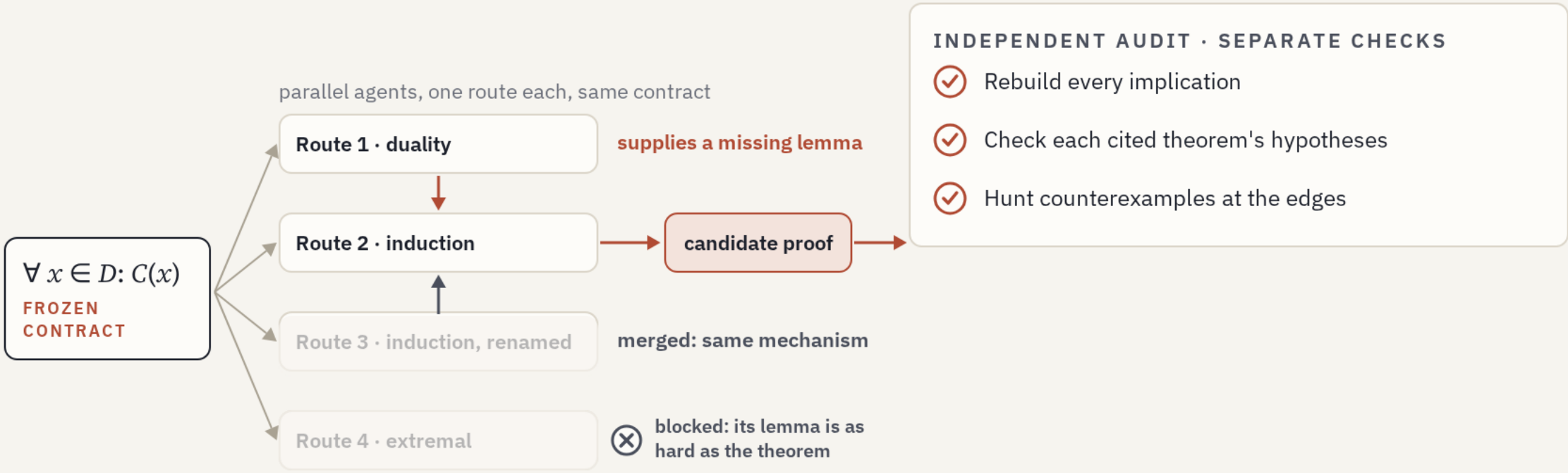
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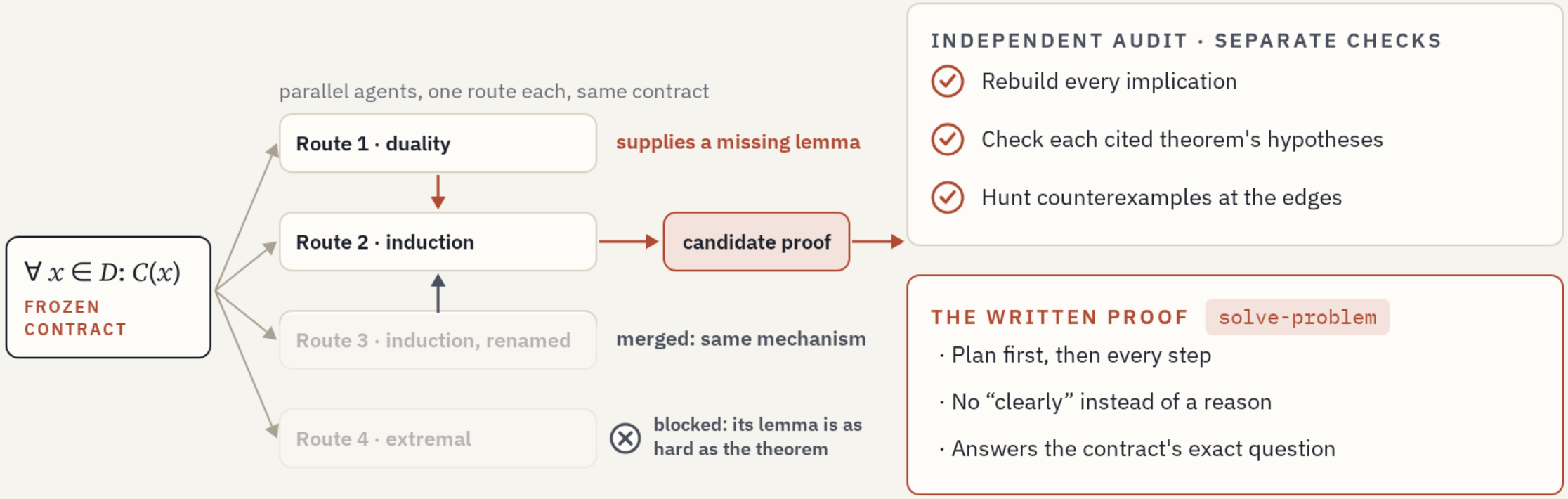
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`solve-problem`

Solve by many routes, then audit the proof.



Search and audit: `formulate-problem` · write-up: `solve-problem`



Solved. Do we understand it?

`teach-material`

`explain-canonically`

Learn the idea first, then every step.

The paper

$$\mathfrak{U}_{k+1} = \mathfrak{U}_k - \eta\, \mathfrak{D}(\mathfrak{U}_k),\ \mathfrak{D} := \partial\mathfrak{L}/\partial\mathfrak{U},\ \|\mathfrak{D}(\mathfrak{U}) - \mathfrak{D}(\mathfrak{V})\| \le \beta\|\mathfrak{U} - \mathfrak{V}\| \Longrightarrow \mathfrak{L}(\mathfrak{U}_k) \downarrow$$

`teach-material`

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Canonical notation

$$\theta_{k+1} = \theta_k - \eta\, \nabla L(\theta_k)$$

$\mathfrak{U} \to \theta \in \mathbb{R}^d$, the parameters · $\mathfrak{L} \to L : \mathbb{R}^d \to \mathbb{R}$, the loss · $\mathfrak{D} \to \nabla L$, its gradient · $\eta > 0$, the step size

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The idea

Every step goes downhill; a smooth slope guarantees a definite drop.

plan: a drop per step → add up the drops

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A toy example

$L(\theta) = \theta^2/2$ in one dimension: $\theta_{k+1} = (1 - \eta)\,\theta_k$, so $\theta_k \to 0$ exactly when $0 < \eta < 2$.



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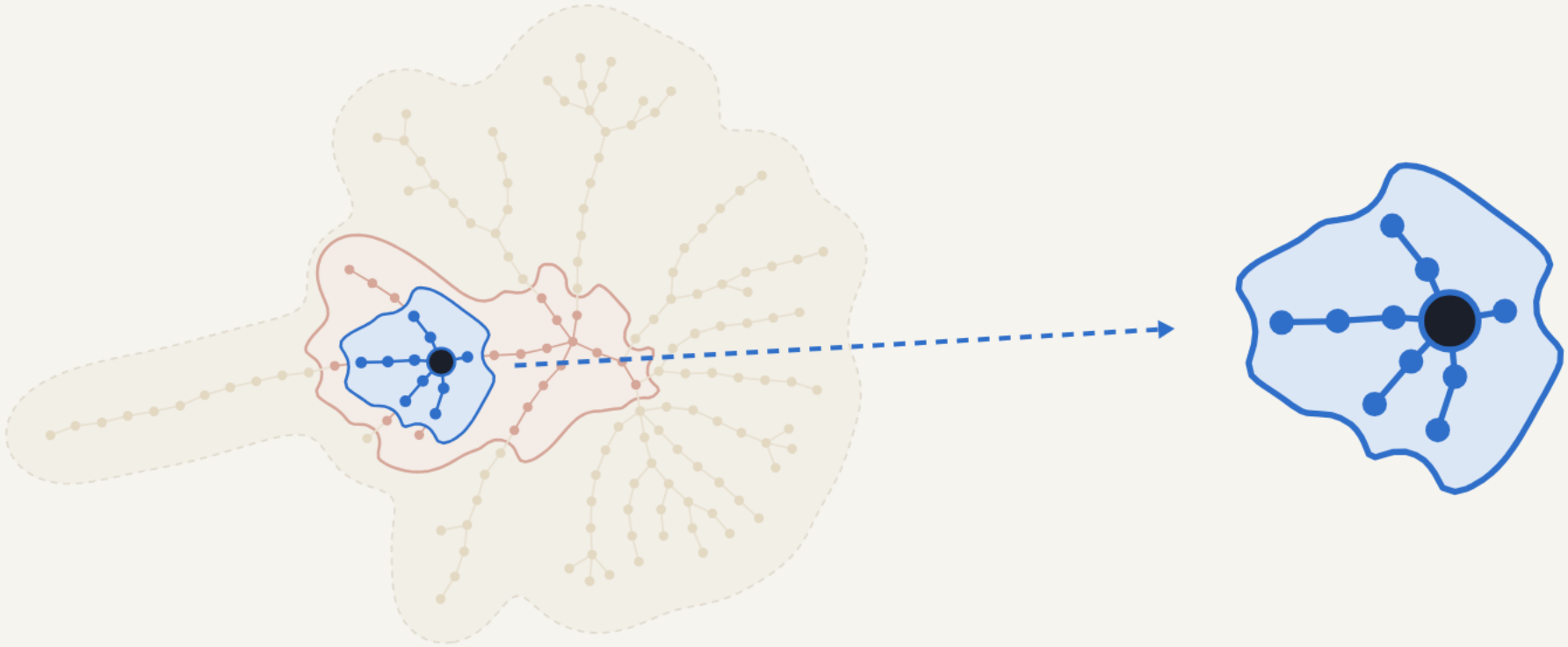
$L(\theta) = \theta^2/2$ in one dimension: $\theta_{k+1} = (1 - \eta)\,\theta_k$, so $\theta_k \to 0$ exactly when $0 < \eta < 2$.



Theorems, checked

Descent lemma: if ∇L is β-Lipschitz, then $L(\theta - \eta\nabla L(\theta)) \le L(\theta) - \eta(1 - \beta\eta/2)\|\nabla L(\theta)\|^2$.

hypothesis ✓ β-Lipschitz, from the paper · with $\eta \le 1/\beta$: drop $\ge (\eta/2)\|\nabla L(\theta_k)\|^2$



Carved out of the core: is it a paper?

10 · ORGANIZE · FORMULATE · SOLVE · LEARN · **AUDIT**

`review-paper`

Audit every claim against its evidence.

the paper, read in full

`review-paper`

Audit every claim against its evidence.



the paper, read in full

- **C1 · key lemma**
- **C2 · main theorem**
- **C3 · novelty**
- **C4 · beats baselines**

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the paper, read in full

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C2 · main theorem

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C4 · beats baselines

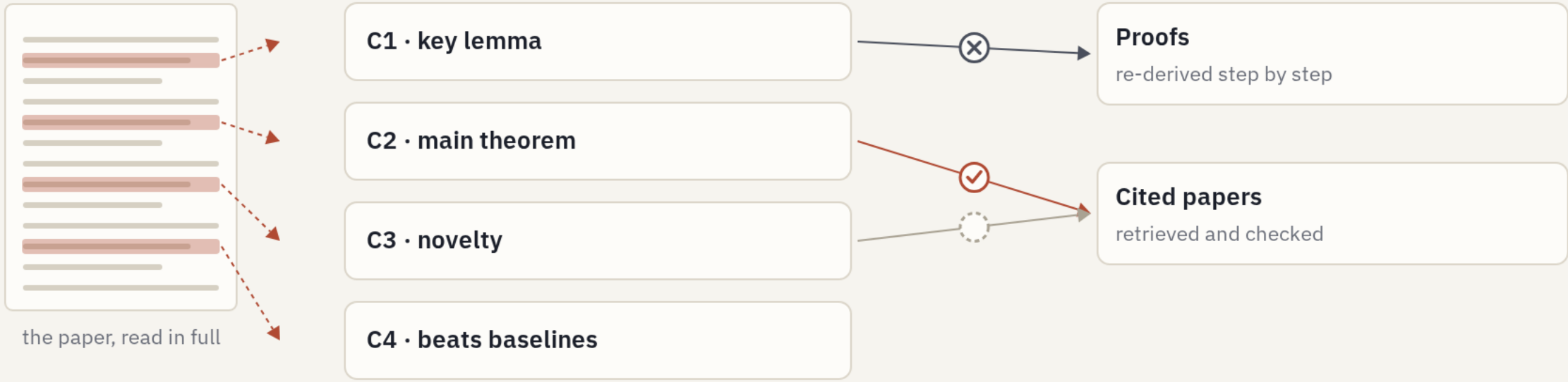
Proofs

re-derived step by step

✓ valid ✕ flawed ○ unverifiable

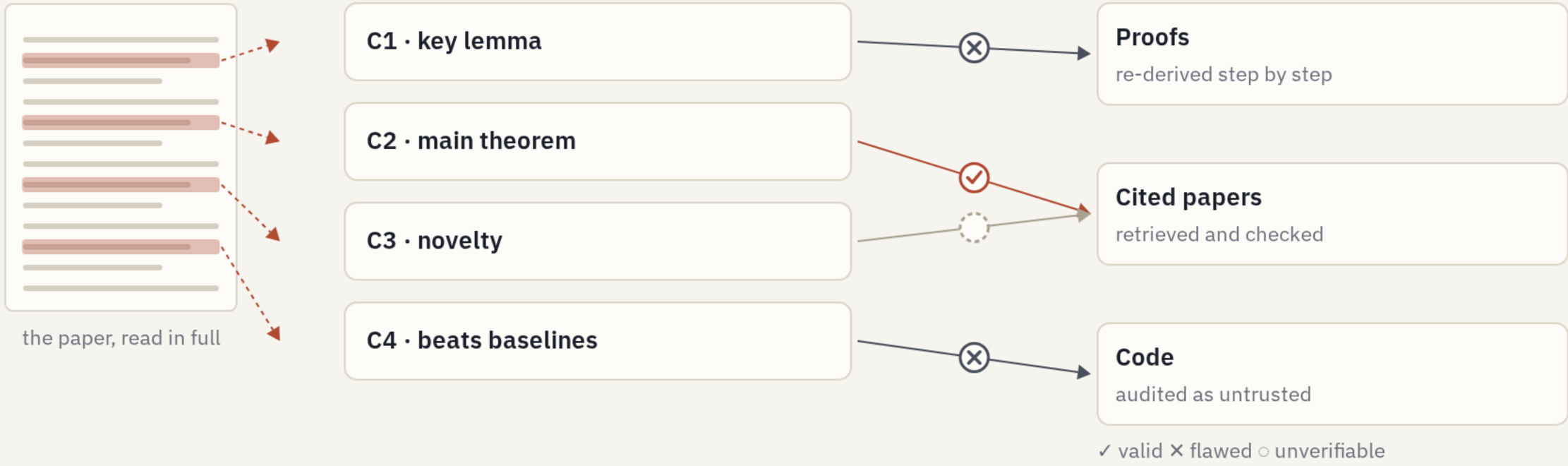
`review-paper`

Audit every claim against its evidence.



`review-paper`

Audit every claim against its evidence.



`review-paper`

Audit every claim against its evidence.



the paper, read in full

C1 · key lemma — PLAUSIBLE — FLAWED PROOF

C2 · main theorem — PLAUSIBLE — DEPENDS ON C1

C3 · novelty — QUESTIONABLE — UNVERIFIED SOURCE

C4 · beats baselines — QUESTIONABLE — UNFAIR BASELINES

Plausibility of the conclusion ≠ soundness of the argument.

Proofs
re-derived step by step

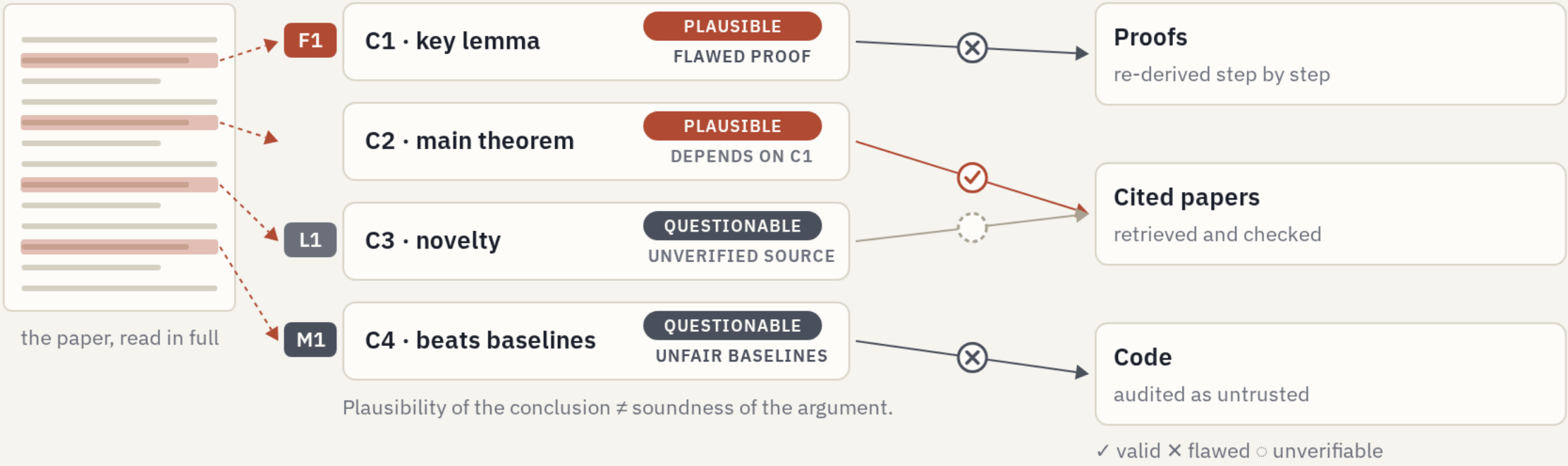
Cited papers
retrieved and checked

Code
audited as untrusted

✓ valid ✕ flawed ○ unverifiable

`review-paper`

Audit every claim against its evidence.



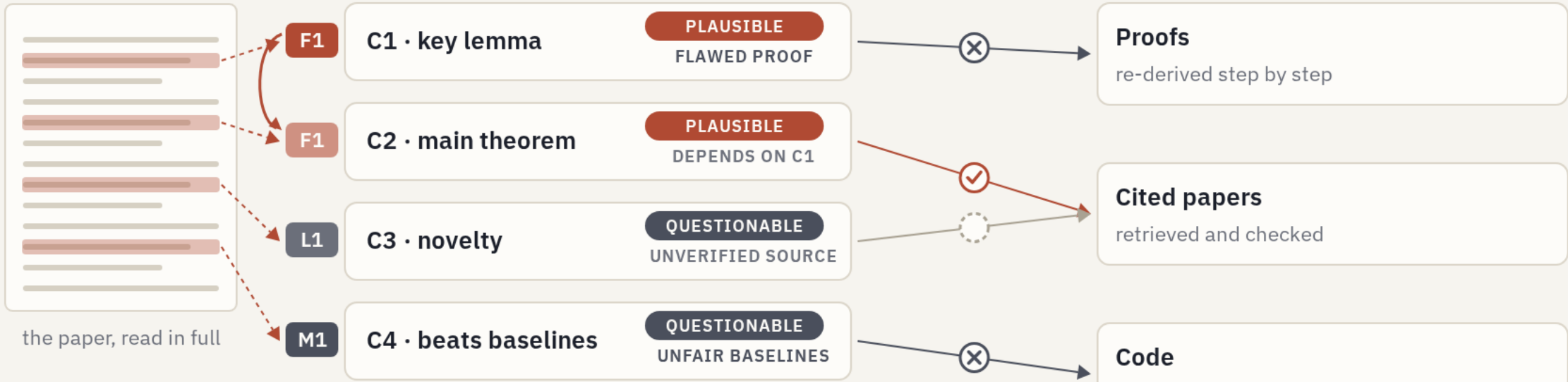
the paper, read in full

Plausibility of the conclusion ≠ soundness of the argument.

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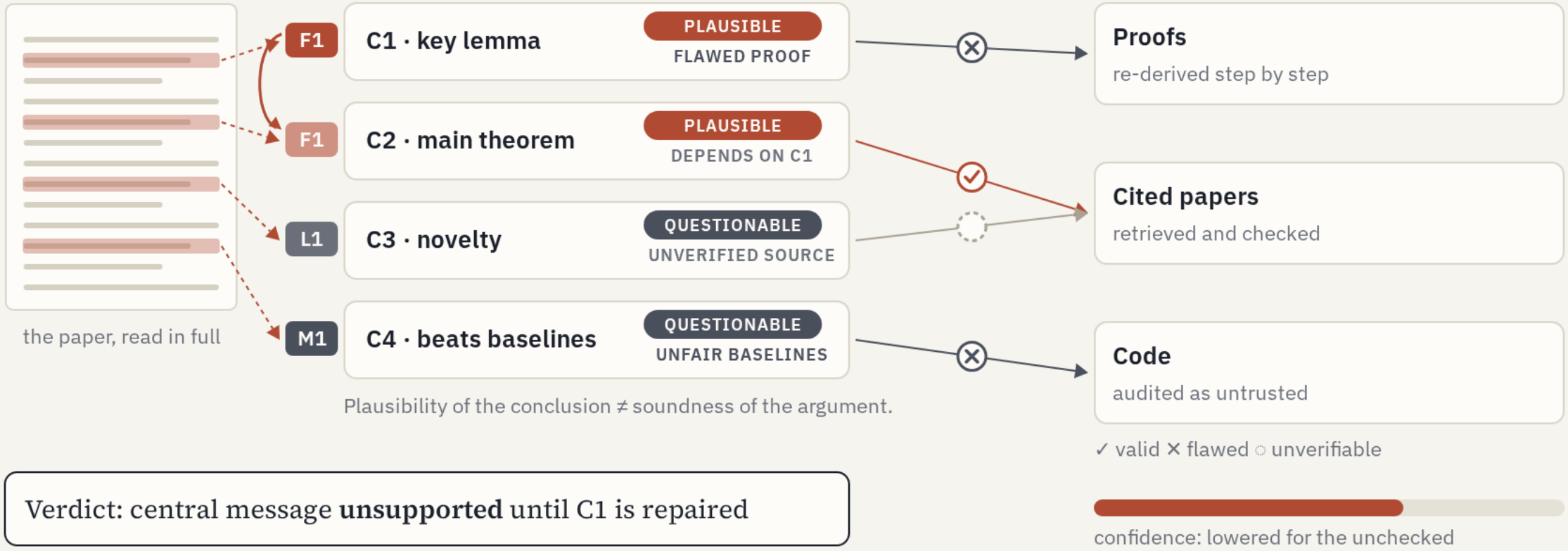


Plausibility of the conclusion ≠ soundness of the argument.

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`review-paper`

Audit every claim against its evidence.



Verdict: central message **unsupported** until C1 is repaired

Putting it all together.

11 · PUTTING IT ALL TOGETHER

From the haystack to the core to the gem.

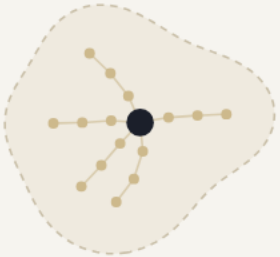
Open-ended question

11 · PUTTING IT ALL TOGETHER

From the haystack to the core to the gem.

organize-research-project
formulate · solve · learn

Open-ended question → Research thrusts

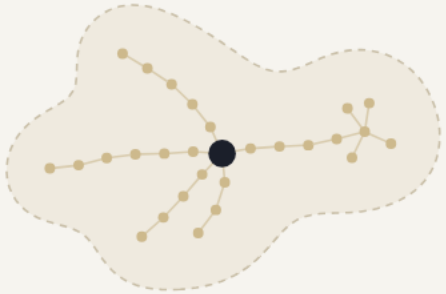


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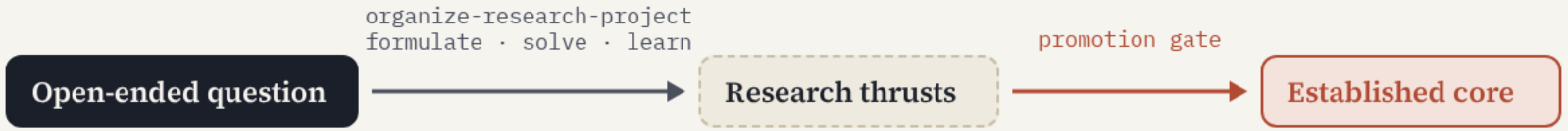
organize-research-project
formulate · solve · learn

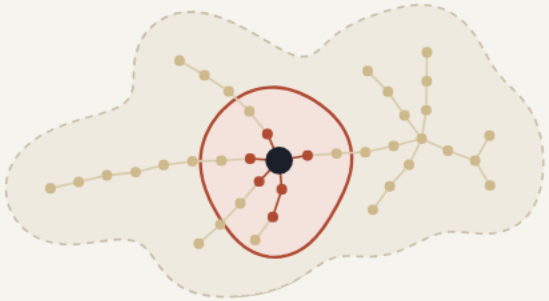
Open-ended question → Research thrusts



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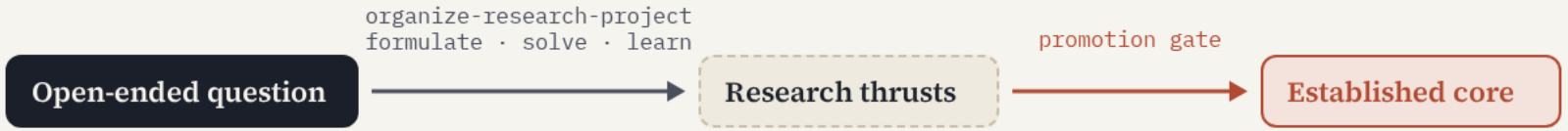
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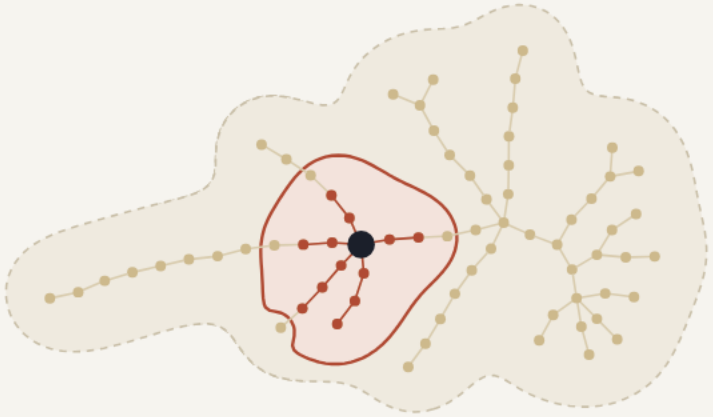




11 · PUTTING IT ALL TOGETHER

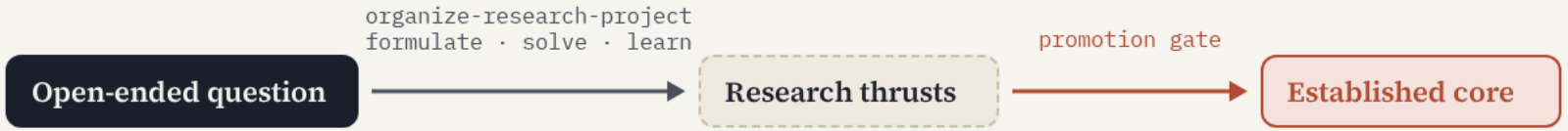
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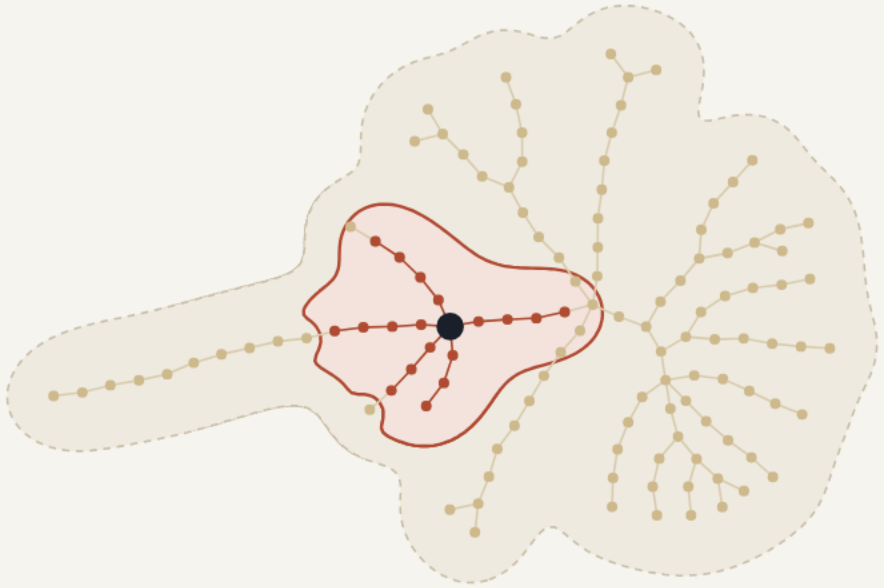




11 · PUTTING IT ALL TOGETHER

From the haystack to the core to the gem.





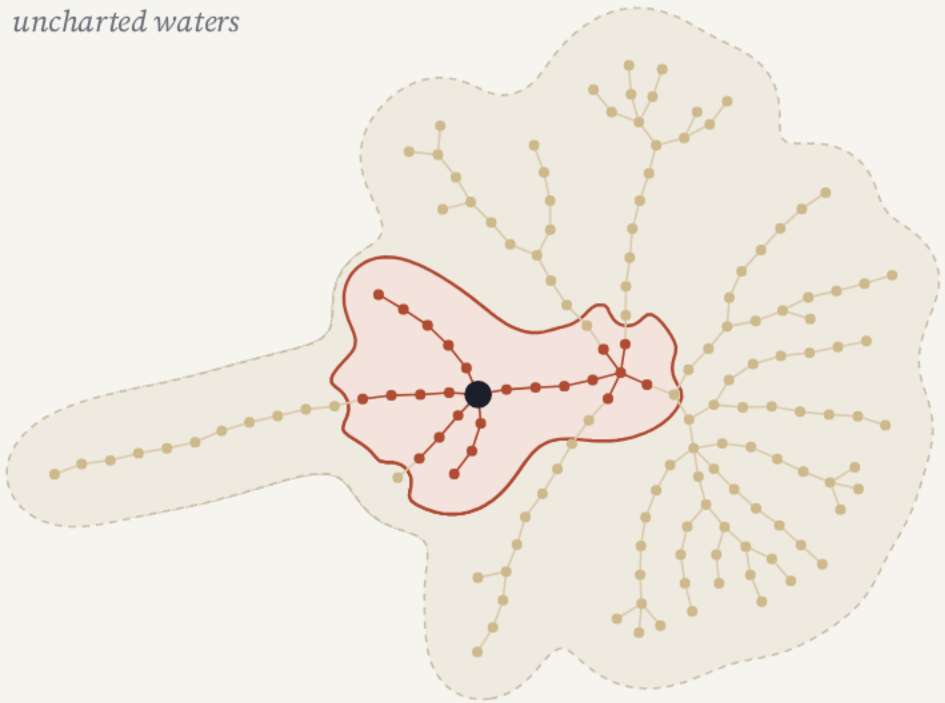
11 · PUTTING IT ALL TOGETHER

From the haystack to the core to the gem.

organize-research-project
formulate · solve · learn

promotion gate

Open-ended question → **Research thrusts** → **Established core**



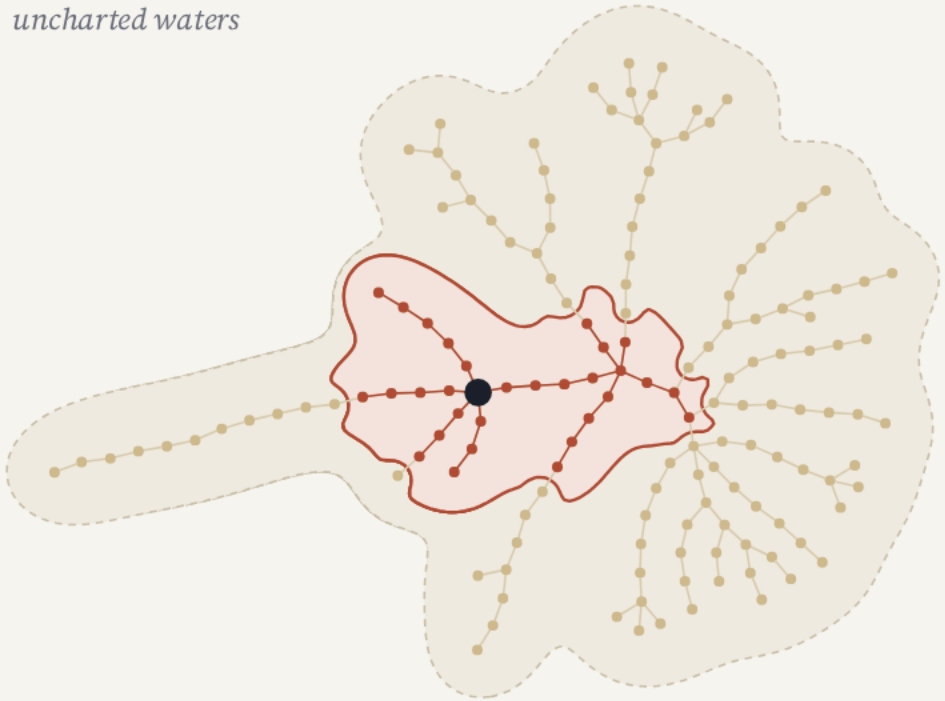
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organize-research-project
formulate · solve · learn

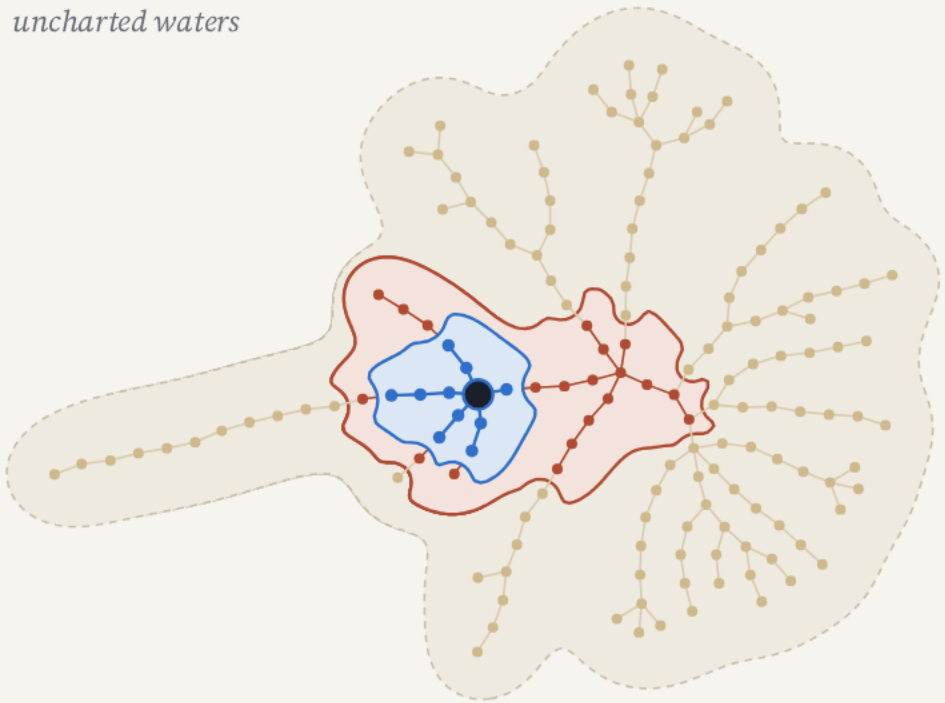
promotion gate

Open-ended question → **Research thrusts** → **Established core**



From the haystack to the core to the gem.

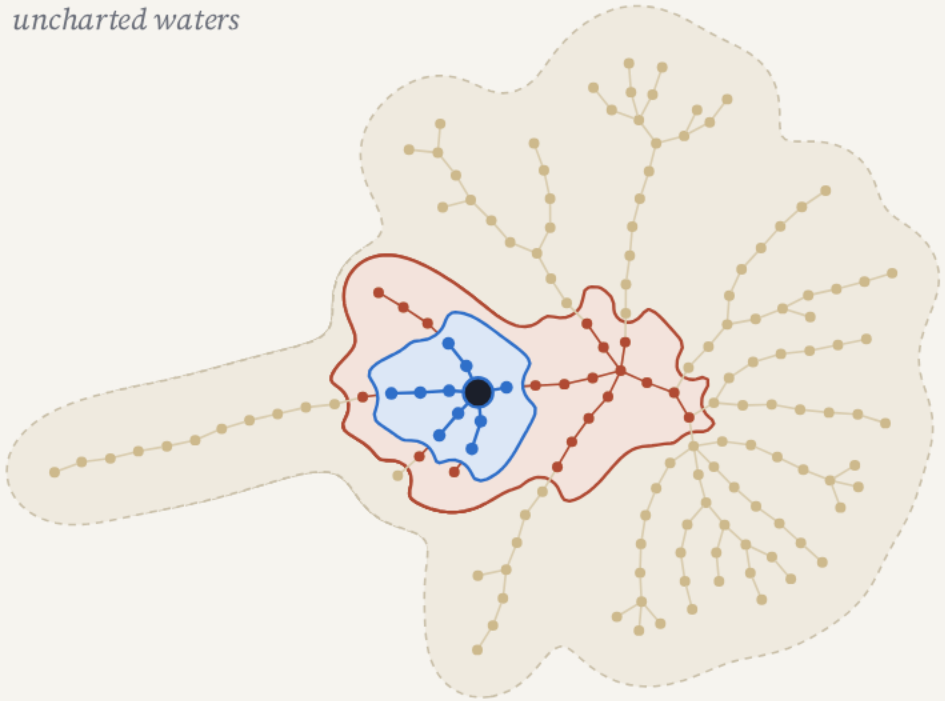




11 · PUTTING IT ALL TOGETHER

From the haystack to the core to the gem.

Open-ended question → (organize-research-project: formulate · solve · learn) → Research thrusts → (promotion gate) → Established core → (review-paper) → Carved-out paper



How to use it

Get

```
git clone \
  github.com/ajoudaki/frontier-research-skills
```

Install

```
ln -s $PWD/<skill> ~/.claude/skills/
# or ~/.codex/skills/ for Codex
```

Or per project

```
name it in AGENTS.md or CLAUDE.md
```

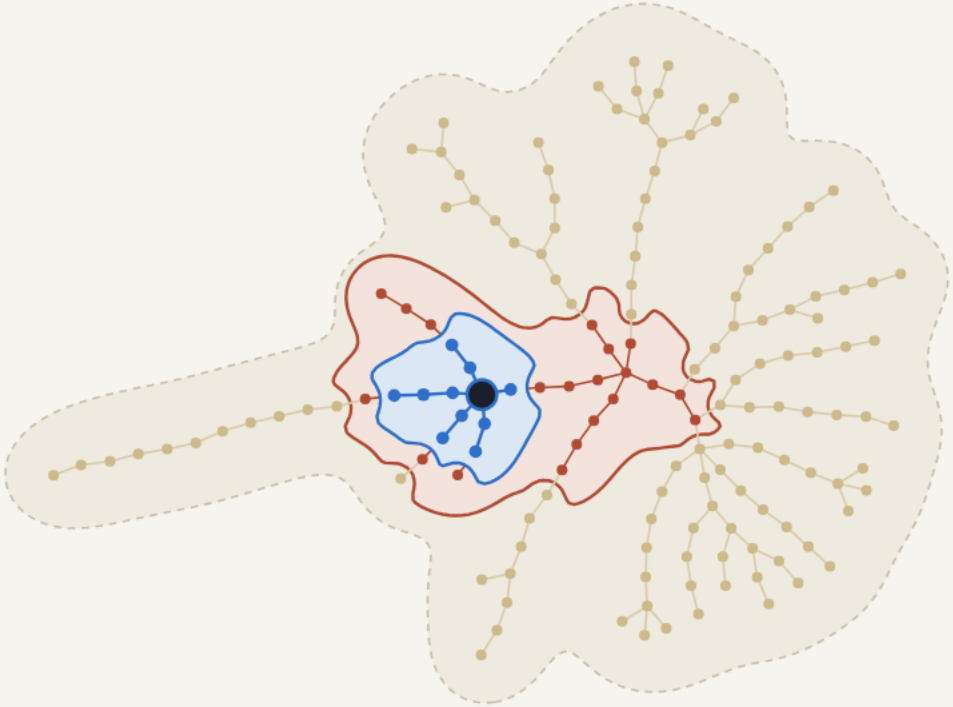
The README has the details.

12 · CONCLUSION

From one question to a gem, and what's next.

12 · CONCLUSION

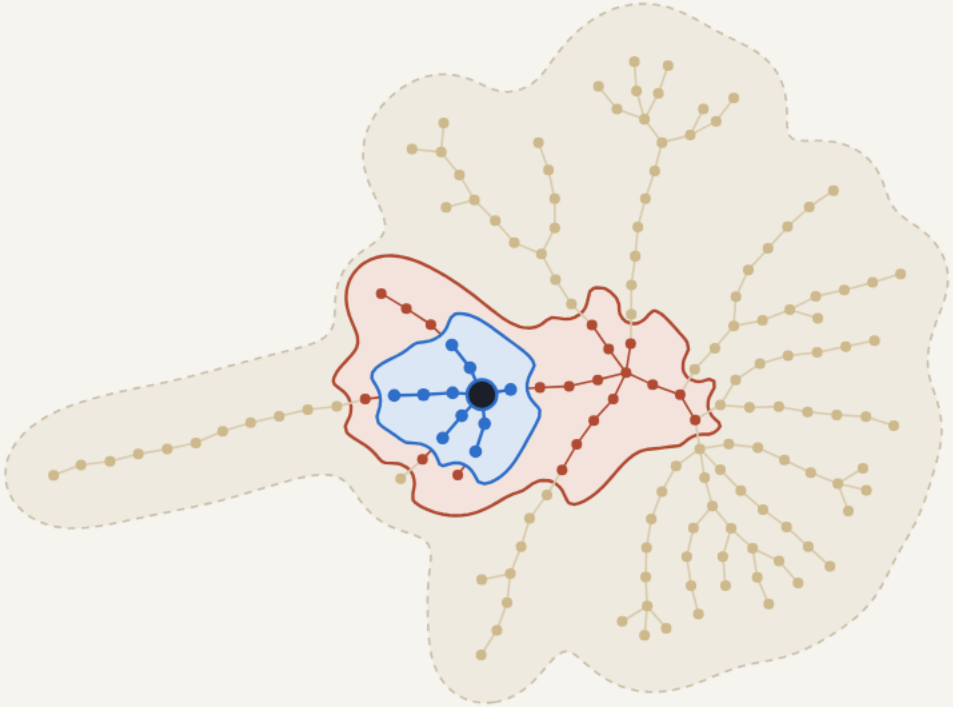
From one question to a gem, and what's next.



open question → thrusts → core → gem

12 · CONCLUSION

From one question to a gem, and what's next.

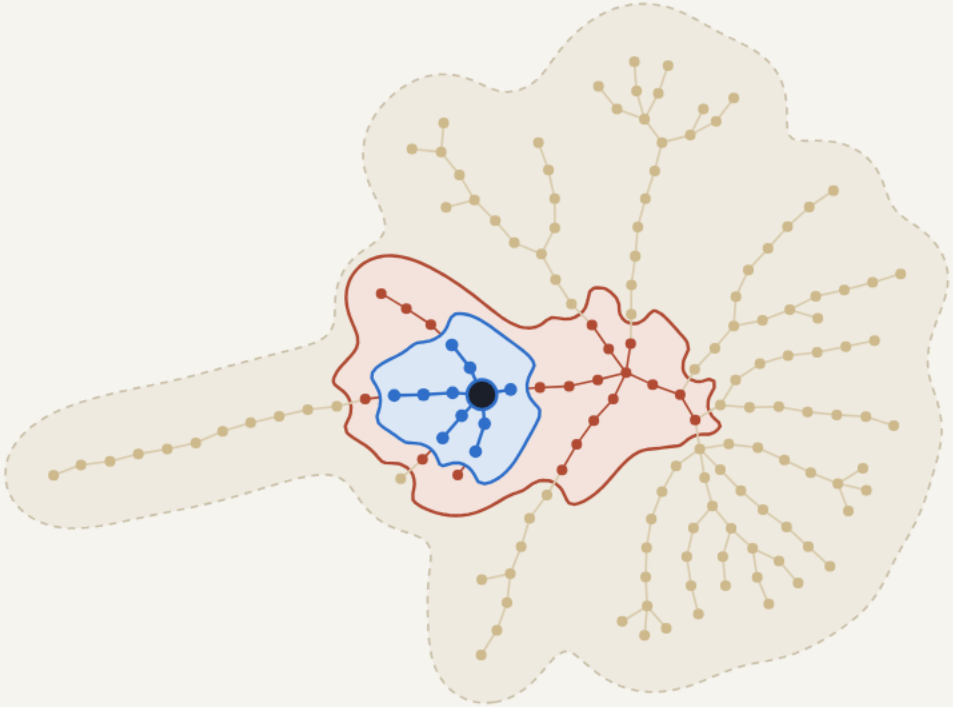


open question → thrusts → core → gem

One goal: raise the signal-to-noise ratio.

12 · CONCLUSION

From one question to a gem, and what's next.



open question → thrusts → core → gem

One goal: raise the signal-to-noise ratio.

WHAT'S NEXT

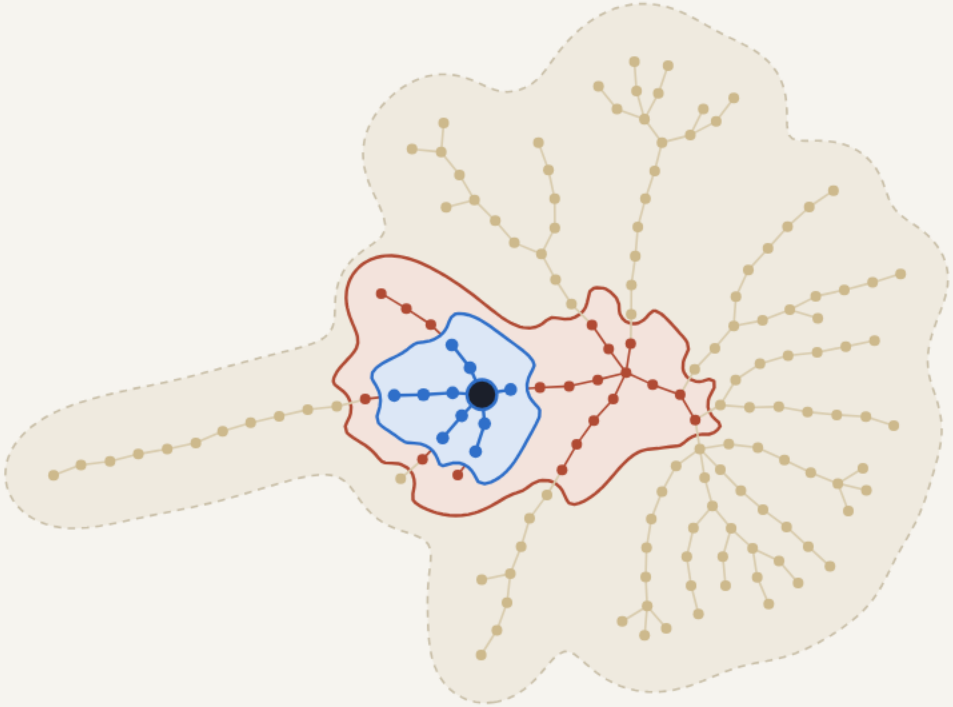
Beyond theory other domains

Evaluations does a change help a skill?

Live skills learn from your chats

12 · CONCLUSION

From one question to a gem, and what's next.



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WHAT'S NEXT

Beyond theory other domains

Evaluations does a change help a skill?

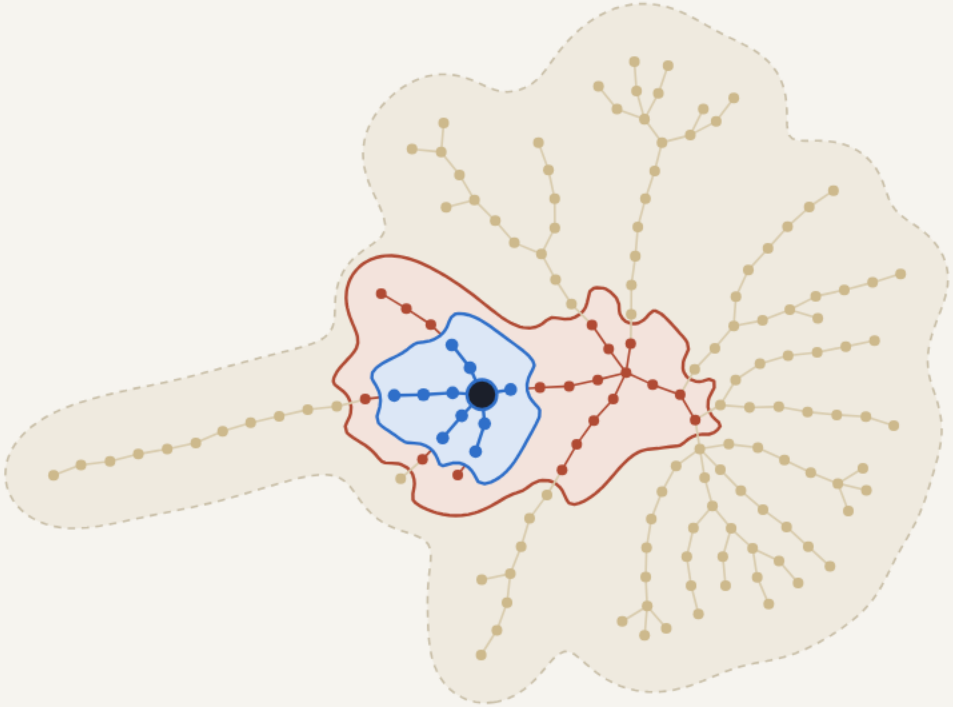
Live skills learn from your chats

THE BIG QUESTION

Can agents learn research taste?

12 · CONCLUSION

From one question to a gem, and what's next.



open question → thrusts → core → gem

One goal: raise the signal-to-noise ratio.

WHAT'S NEXT

Beyond theory other domains

Evaluations does a change help a skill?

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THE BIG QUESTION

Can agents learn research taste?

github.com/ajoudaki/frontier-research-skills

Thank you.